# Prosperity Script

Oct 15, 2026 · @Nathan

**Version 6** · 2026-10-15 08:17 CDT

This is the script for feedback: the 4-page prologue and Bob's Chapters 1–6, following his drafts closely. Chapters 1–3 include his v5 revisions; Chapters 4–6 are his fifth draft as written. The only changes to his story are his own v5 notes in answer to Young Americans Center, and Adrian's watch in place of the casino chip. Comment on any line.

## What changed from Bob's fifth draft

Everything else is Bob's fifth draft: his scenes, their order and his dialogue.

| Change | Where | Source |
|---|---|---|
| Bob's Chapter 1 revisions: the three-city opening with one question per city, water rationed and visible from page 1, the debt-transfer page, a clear first quest to the Measure | Chapter 1 | Bob's Chapter 1 v5 brief |
| Bob's Chapter 2 revisions: Alpha and the safeguards made concrete, the mine simplified, "The Lie" (62% reported, 18% delivered) set up and paid off, why Alex leaves, the train | Chapter 2 | Bob's Chapter 2 v5 brief |
| Bob's Chapter 3 revisions: Lock as a real alternative, the collaborators' reasons, prototypes that fail first, a licensing business instead of a giveaway, the first 38 credits earned and 12 paid on the debt | Chapter 3 | Bob's Chapter 3 v5 brief and mission notes |
| Adrian's old steel watch replaces the casino chip; the equation is engraved on its caseback | All chapters | Showrunner |
| Invented House names: Calder (water), Ivers (energy and compute), Steyn (mining and | Chapter 3 | Showrunner |

| Change | Where | Source |
|---|---|---|
| launch), replacing real company names | | |
| The prologue, "The Wall" | Before Chapter 1 | Showrunner |

Not applied: the writers' room's own revisions for the backer, the partner and "school smell".

## Prologue: The Wall

### Page 1: The house

**P1: The house (wide)**

*Image:* Alex's house at evening, in 2070, built the way Oasis was built in 2043: the book's own Oasis, now ordinary and lived in. Pearl-white curved architecture with rounded rooflines, terraced gardens, a still reservoir with fountains, slender white towers and a white monorail viaduct across the basin, the snow mountains behind, a delivery drone in the dusk sky. One house in a neighbourhood of them, modest for Oasis: a workbench and a bike on the terrace, plants that need watering. Never present-day suburbia.

**P2: The wall (medium)**

*Image:* Inside, an Oasis-built hallway: smooth pearl-white curved walls, warm wood floor, a tall window onto the terraces. The wall is covered in framed patents, drawings of machines and news clippings. Alex, mid-40s, grey at the temples, a day's stubble, still dressed like a mechanic: a worn work jacket over a T-shirt, sleeves pushed up, scuffed boots; Adrian's old steel watch on his left wrist. His daughter, about 9: warm-brown skin, freckles, dark auburn-brown hair in two low braids, a mustard cardigan over a pale blue school shirt, navy skirt, white socks, red sneakers. She stands on tiptoe in front of the wall.

**P3: The clippings (close)**

*Image:* Close on the clippings, seen and never read aloud: "40TH INDEPENDENT SHOP LICENSES PHANTUM PURIFIER"; "SMALL MAKERS AND THE HOUSES RACE FOR THE NEXT DESIGN”; a picture of dozens of founders, each with their own water unit and a different shop sign. Every picture is drawn in the book's own inked style.

**P4: The question**

DAUGHTER: Did you make *all* of these?

### Page 2: The inventions

**P1: The collaborators**

*Image:* Alex taps a framed picture of four people laughing in a lab: Lina, Suri, Jalen and Ren, never named.

ALEX: Made some. Fixed most. Worked with some people smarter than me.

**P2: The purifier**

*Image:* She points at a patent with a purifier diagram.

DAUGHTER: That one's in my school!

**P3: The first try**

*Image:* One frame among the patents is a drawing of a scorched, cracked prototype, with "v1 - didn't work" written on it in his hand. Neither of them remarks on it.

**P4: Paid in full (small)**

*Image:* Small and almost hidden in a corner, a framed final account statement: **PAID IN FULL · BALANCE 0 CREDITS**. The daughter doesn't notice it. She stops at one frame that doesn't match the others.

## Page 3: The sketch

**P1: The sketch (close)**

*Image:* A crumpled, grease-stained sheet with a pencil sketch of a pump bracket. Crude, smudged fingerprints, no patent number.

**P2: Why not a patent**

DAUGHTER: This one's just a drawing. Why isn't it a patent?

ALEX: Because it never needed to be.

**P3: Fun**

*Image:* The daughter, beaming.

DAUGHTER: Inventing stuff must have been *so* much fun.

**P4: The watch (close)**

*Image:* Alex looks at the sketch, then down at the watch. His thumb covers its face.

## Page 4: The turn

**P1**

ALEX: Not in the beginning.

**P2**

*Image:* The daughter looks up at him, waiting.

**P3**

ALEX: In the beginning I was deep in debt, our water was rationed...

**P4: Keel (full width)**

*Image:* The sketch dissolves into the rust and charcoal of Keel's pump hall. Seventeen-year-old Alex has his palm flat on the pump.

*Caption:* KEEL. 2043.

## Chapter 1: The Inheritance

### Page 1: The world Alex inherits

A full-page cinematic establishing image of the three-tier civilization in the year 2043, viewed from a distant elevated angle so all three cities read in one composition.

At the bottom of a vast mountain basin lies **KEEL**, built into and around an exhausted open-pit lithium mine. Dense stacked housing, repaired industrial equipment, rusted mining structures, crowded pedestrian lanes and aging factories fill the basin. Dust hangs in the air. Workers pass through small digital checkpoints. Water moves through narrow channels and old pipes, and a line of people with jugs waits at a metered public tap. The palette is rust, charcoal and oxidized orange. A large sealed mine entrance on the pit's rim is marked with faded hazard striping. Low in the basin, a single aging pump gantry has one small work-light on.

Midway up lies **HALYARD**, visibly more prosperous and active. Workshops, fabrication towers, irrigated greenhouse terraces, elevated trains and advanced industrial facilities line the slope, and freight moves both up and down. The palette is warm bronze and gold with engineered green. Three towering fabrication complexes each carry a distinct, restrained insignia for energy, water and space. These are the Charter Houses.

Above both, partly beyond the cloud layer, lies **OASIS**: pearl-white architecture, designed gardens, broad reservoirs, open fountains, civic spaces and automated transit. The palette is pearl white, silver, cool blue and controlled green. A spacecraft rises toward orbit from a distant launch structure, carrying the same space-and-mining insignia as the largest Halyard tower.

The three cities share **one spine of infrastructure**: a massive water conduit, energy lines, transit rails and control nodes running vertically through the mountain.

- The conduit is enormous at Oasis's reservoirs and narrows dramatically by the time it reaches Keel's channels.
- One small, identical white-and-amber control node sits on the spine at every tier.
- Access gates multiply toward Keel, including a permission gate across the rail line between Keel and Halyard.

**Captions**

- Date tag: **Year 2043.**
- City labels (small, map-style): **Oasis · Halyard · Keel**
- Caption over Oasis: *What if everyone you've trusted has a secret?*
- Caption over Halyard: *Who really owns what we create?*
- Caption over Keel: *Where does all our water go?*

### Page 2: Debt transfer day

**Panel 1: Alex at work (wide)**

*Image:* A Keel pump hall just before dawn, in the rust, charcoal and oxidized-orange language of Page 1. Alex Phantum, seventeen, lean and mechanically capable, has one palm flat on an aging pump's housing, head tilted, feeling the vibration rather than reading the gauge. A projected maintenance procedure hovers beside him, unfollowed. His improvised repair is visible: a salvaged bracket where the approved part should be. Decades of patched machinery surround him. On the wall terminal, a small white-and-amber node logs his shift. A supervisor watches with folded arms and open skepticism. Alex reads self-reliant, not defeated.

SUPERVISOR: That's not the approved repair.

ALEX: Then don't approve it.

*(Beat.)*

ALEX: Just notice it works.

**Panel 2: The checkpoint (medium-wide)**

*Image:* End of shift at the exit checkpoint. Alex, in worn mining clothes with a weathered tool bag, tired and dirty, puts his hand on the scanner, whose housing carries the same white-and-amber node. Workers queue silently, each with a balance floating overhead, mostly in the tens of thousands. When his scan completes, his becomes the largest in the queue. Everyone glances up. No one speaks.

*Display, under a banner reading* **TODAY: DEBT TRANSFER DAY**

ALEX PHANTUM

AGE VERIFIED: SEVENTEEN

PARENTAL HOUSEHOLD LIABILITY TRANSFER: COMPLETE

GUARANTOR: ADRIAN PHANTUM — WHEREABOUTS UNRECORDED

DEBT BALANCE: 418,607 CREDITS

EARNED TODAY: 40 CREDITS

PROJECTED CLEARANCE: 28.7 YEARS

TRAVEL STATUS: RESTRICTED

*SFX:* BEEP

GUARD: Happy birthday, Phantum.

ALEX: I've had better surprises.

*Caption:* Seventeen: the age Keel decides you're old enough to owe.

**Panel 3: The Last Chance (wide)**

*Image:* Morning street. Alex passes a shuttered casino whose faded lights still flicker: **THE LAST CHANCE.** On its outer wall is a peeling poster of a man's face, mostly torn away, a cautionary legend rather than a portrait. A bouncer, at the end of his night, leans in the doorway. On Alex's left wrist, half under his

sleeve, is Adrian's old steel watch, a little big for him, its small display window dark. He doesn't notice he's tugging the sleeve down over it. Across the street, people queue at a metered public water tap whose display reads **RATION: 4 L**.

BOUNCER: Care to see if luck runs in the family?

BOUNCER: Your father always believed the next hand would change everything.

*(Alex doesn't answer. His thumb covers the watch's face and he keeps walking, eyes ahead.)*

**Panel 4: The log (small cutaway, no Alex)**

*Image:* The pump hall, empty now, with sunlight through the high window. The supervisor stands alone at the wall terminal. The white-and-amber node blinks beside a red flag reading **UNAUTHORIZED REPAIR — REVIEW REQUIRED.** Behind him the pump hums steadily. He looks at the pump, then at the flag, and his thumb selects **ROUTINE MAINTENANCE.** A green check appears. At the pump's base, a balanced water-drop symbol is scratched into an old valve plate.

SUPERVISOR *(muttering)*: ...Works.

**Panel 5: The rim (tall)**

*Image:* Sunrise on the rim of Keel's exhausted pit. In the foreground, unnoticed by Alex, is the sealed mine entrance with faded hazard striping. Alex stands beyond it, fists clenched, the old watch on his wrist, leaning toward Oasis, whose white towers catch the first sunlight while the basin below is still in shadow. On his wrist the display glows faintly: **TRAVEL STATUS: RESTRICTED.**

*Caption:* Everyone in Keel knew where they had been born. / Few believed they could choose where they belonged.

ALEX *(small bubble)*: One day... I'm leaving.

## Page 3: Two different dreams

**P1: The overlook (wide)**

*Image:* Late afternoon on the rim of Keel's exhausted pit, at the rusted railing from Page 2's last panel, now worn smooth where they always sit. The mountain is a soft backdrop, with Keel in shadow, Halyard's terraces catching gold and Oasis in sunlight. The sealed mine entrance is faint at the far left edge. Bolted to the railing beside them is a weathered metal plaque, half-scoured by dust: **WATER WARS MEMORIAL**, above a dry, cracked drinking fountain that has not run in years. Alex sits on the railing eating a simple packed lunch, shoulders down, fists unclenched. Ada is small in the frame, approaching along the rim with two battered metal mugs of water. Warm gold light, long shadows.

*Caption:* Later that afternoon...

**P2: The offer (medium)**

*Image:* Ada reaches Alex and holds out a mug. She is eighteen, with long, wind-tangled copper hair, freckles and teal-blue eyes. She wears a dark high-collared top with a rivet-studded strap across one

shoulder and a muted moss-green wrap at her neck, and her stance is steady and rooted. Alex looks up and smiles.

ADA: Thought you might need this.

ALEX: The birthday special? Not sure I can afford it.

**P3: Not everything (close)**

*Image:* Close on their hands and faces around the mugs of clear water. Alex has stopped with the mug halfway to his mouth, looking at her, knowing what it cost. Ada has a small, steady smile. At her hip hangs a ration card with one day's mark punched out. Rust-gold light.

ALEX: Where'd you get enough water for two?

ADA: Saved some of my ration.

ALEX: Ada, you didn't have to.

ADA: Not everything has a price, Alex.

**P4: Chemistry (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* The two seated side by side on the railing, mugs in hand. Alex looks out at the distance and Ada looks at him. Both are laughing, like people who have known each other forever.

ADA: Seventeen. Congratulations. You're officially old.

ALEX: I'm officially broke.

**P5: The quiet beat (small)**

*Image:* Ada's eyes in the foreground, on Alex. Beyond her, Alex shrugs and looks away toward the horizon. The laughter has gone out of the light.

ADA: I heard about this morning.

ALEX: Everyone did.

*(Ada lets the silence sit.)*

**P6: Two dreams (wide, split eyelines)**

*Image:* Over-the-shoulder from behind. Alex's head tilts up toward Oasis, catching the last sunlight. Ada's gaze angles down toward Keel in shadow, her copper hair lifted by the wind. The railing cuts the frame diagonally between them, and the mountain is only a sliver.

ALEX: Every birthday... I look up there... and wonder what it feels like to wake up somewhere you get to choose your own future.

ADA: I look down here... and wonder why everyone gave up trying to change it.

ALEX: Because nobody leaves.

ADA: That's the problem. People stopped trying to make it worth staying.

## Page 4: What people told him

**P1: The photograph (medium)**

*Image:* Alex draws a worn photograph half out of his jacket pocket. His grandmother smiles, and Adrian's face is folded over and creased where Alex has hidden it. His other hand pulls his sleeve down over Adrian's old watch. Ada notices both. Light turning from gold to amber.

ADA: How's your grandma?

**P2: Alex answers (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex looks at the photograph, and Ada sits beside him. After his lines, her hand lifts toward his shoulder and stops in the air.

ALEX: Some days she knows me. Other days she calls me Adrian...

ALEX: The hardest part isn't that she forgets. It's that she makes up crazy stories about him.

**P3: The stories (wide)**

*Image:* They stand at the railing. The sun begins to set, Oasis glows brighter and Keel dims. Ada faces Alex, not the view.

ADA: What kind of stories?

ALEX: That he wasn't gambling. That he was working.

*(Ada lets the silence sit.)*

**P4: What he remembers (tight)**

*Image:* Ada's face, close and steady. In the foreground, Alex's thumb covers the watch's face.

ADA: What do you actually remember about him?

ALEX: Nothing. I was two.

**P5: The crack (wide, quiet)**

*Image:* Both figures small against the darkening basin, with Oasis the brightest thing in the frame. Ada faces Alex, and he stands stiff with his eyes on the horizon.

ADA: So everything else is what people told you. What if they were wrong?

*(Alex stiffens. A long silence.)*

ALEX: Maybe…Or maybe they're right. Either way... he's gone.

**P6: Hook (narrow strip)**

*Image:* They begin walking home at dusk. Alex is ahead, and Ada lingers, looking back toward Oasis.

ADA *(very small bubble, almost to herself)*: He wouldn't just leave.

## Page 5: The old book

**P1: Establishing (wide)**

*Image:* Interior of a modest Keel apartment at dusk, seen from just inside the front door. Handmade quilts, repaired furniture, shelves of old books, faded family photographs and potted plants in recycled containers, and two water jugs by the door with ration marks scratched down their sides. Warm rust-orange evening light comes through dusty windows. Grandmother sits at the centre in a worn chair, back partly to us, folding and refolding a small cloth. On the far right wall, a tall floor-to-ceiling bookshelf is the largest object in the room, with one book-width gap at eye height. Alex is a small silhouette in the doorway, tool bag on his shoulder. The room is warm, lived-in and dignified.

GRANDMOTHER *(from the chair)*: Adrian?

**P2: Inset close-up**

*Image:* Alex in the doorway with his eyes closed for a moment, jaw tight, shoulders dropping.

ALEX: Not today, Grandma. It's Alex.

**P3: Kneeling (medium)**

*Image:* Alex kneels beside the chair at her eye level. Her hands keep folding the cloth. His smile is gentle and tired. Warm side light.

GRANDMOTHER: Of course. Alex. I knew that. Did your father come home yet?

ALEX: Not yet.

**P4: The hinge (tight close-up)**

*Image:* Grandmother's face and eyes. For one beat the fog clears and her gaze is steady and studying, a little too careful. Behind her, out of focus, Alex still smiles, unaware.

GRANDMOTHER: He's closer than you think.

**P5: The handoff (close on hands)**

*Image:* Her frail hands pass a worn, hand-bound book to Alex's scarred, work-rough hands. The cover is worn from decades of use, and a faint balanced water-drop mark sits on the spine.

GRANDMOTHER: Would you put this away for me? Your father never liked seeing it left out.

ALEX: He had opinions about everything.

**P6: Toward the shelf (tall, narrow)**

*Image:* Alex from behind, book in hand, walking toward the looming bookshelf. His shadow reaches the gap at eye height, and the warm room light is behind him.

GRANDMOTHER *(off-panel)*: Especially the things worth protecting.

## Page 6: The hidden workshop

**P1: Click (small).** Close on Alex's hand pressing the old book into the gap. It stops at an exact depth, and dust puffs from the shelf edge. *SFX:* CLICK.

**P2: Rumble (small).** Alex turns his head, listening. Behind him the shelf edge has shifted by a hair and dust sifts down. *SFX:* RUMBLE.

**P3: The reveal (dominant).** From inside the room, at a slightly low angle. The whole bookshelf has swung outward like a door, with a black rectangle behind it. A golden wedge of household light spills across the dusty floor into the dark. Alex stands mid-ground, stepping back. Grandmother sits unbothered in the far background, still folding her cloth.

ALEX: ...Grandma?

**P4: The answer (medium).** Grandmother is calm and smiling. Alex turns from the dark toward her.

GRANDMOTHER: He said you'd know when you were ready.

ALEX: When did he say that?

GRANDMOTHER: Before he went to work.

**P5: The threshold (strip).** Low, close on Alex's boot. The golden light ends at the edge of the dark, and his foot crosses the line. No dialogue.

## Page 7: What he left

**P1: The room (wide).** The workshop from the threshold, with Alex small at lower left. The room is frozen in time and thick with dust, with cool blue-grey ambience. Blueprints are pinned to the walls, and there are mechanical models, water-system diagrams and prototype devices. Old photographs are turned or too faded to read. A large chalkboard is covered in dense equations, including one in the same looping form as the equation engraved on the caseback of Alex's watch. Riveted pre-Alpha pipes and analog gauges run through the back wall. At the centre stands one perfectly organized workbench under a pool of warm amber light. On it sits a child-sized seated shape under a dust sheet, with a faint amber pulse beneath the cloth, and beside it a beautiful metallic key with a circular head bearing an unfamiliar symbol.

**P2: The watch (medium).** Alex's hand has stopped halfway through tugging his sleeve down; the watch's steel edge glints. His eyes are on the chalkboard.

**P3: The match (medium).** The chalkboard, with one equation in a looping form, identical in shape to the engraving on the watch's caseback.

**P4: The bench (wide).** A child-sized seated shape under a dust sheet with a faint amber pulse beneath the cloth. Beside it lies a beautiful metallic key with a circular head bearing an unfamiliar symbol. Alex's open hand enters from the left edge, reaching but not touching.

**Hook inset:** Extreme close-up of the key. The symbol catches the light.

## Page 8: The awakening

**P1: The sheet (wide)**

*Image:* Alex pulls the dust sheet away from the seated shape, and dust cascades through the amber pool. The figure is revealed with dull glass eyes and an open key socket in its chest, where a faint amber pulse still beats. The long metal key is in Alex's other fist; the watch is half hidden under his sleeve. His expression is cautious awe. No dialogue.

**P2: The test (small)**

*Image:* Extreme close-up of Alex's palm flat on the figure's chest, fingers spread, head tilted as he feels for vibration, the way he tests pumps. Under his palm, the amber pulse answers, slow and warm. No dialogue.

**P3: The key (medium)**

*Image:* Close on the metal key from the workbench, a long shaft with teeth and a circular head, sliding shaft-first into the chest socket, his scarred knuckles tense and a slight tremor in his hand. It is the key, not the watch; the watch stays on his wrist.

*SFX:* CLICK

**P4: The ignition (dominant)**

*Image:* A low angle from Alex's eyeline. The figure's eyes ignite warm amber. A ring of dust lifts from its shoulders, and warm light glints on a round, segmented blue head and chipped mustard-yellow paint, with an old rust-red scarf at the neck, filling the near space. Alex is at the frame's edge, edge-lit only, stepping back.

*SFX:* WHIRRR... (rising)

**P5: First words (short)**

*Image:* Bi11bot stretches stiff mechanical arms, his joints creaking and dust falling. The heavy rings around his eyes rotate with a click. His gaze hasn't reached Alex yet. Alex is out of focus behind him, frozen.

BI11BOT: ...Well. That took longer than expected.

## Page 9: The robot who bet

**P1: The recoil (medium-wide)**

*Image:* Alex jumps backward, knocking a stool over, hands half-raised. Bi11bot is dusting off his shoulders in the foreground, head just turning toward him. The amber ambience glows around the machine.

ALEX: Okay. That's... new.

**P2: The pause (tight, silent)**

*Image:* Extreme close-up of Bi11bot's face. Amber eyes narrow to focus, and the heavy eye rings rotate with a click as his head tilts. It is a beat of deciding how much not to say.

**P3: His mistakes (medium)**

*Image:* Over Bi11bot's shoulder. Alex stands small behind him, arms crossed in his armored stance.

BI11BOT: You're taller than your father predicted.

ALEX: Everyone in Keel claims they knew my father.

BI11BOT: Most of them knew his reputation. I knew his mistakes.

**P4: The glance (medium)**

*Image:* Bi11bot's eyes drop toward Alex's left wrist, where the watch's steel edge shows under his sleeve. Alex pulls the sleeve down.

BI11BOT: And you kept the watch.

ALEX: You know about the watch?

**P5: The bet (close)**

*Image:* Alex slowly unbuckles the watch and turns it over in his palm, the equation engraved on the caseback visible. Bi11bot's mustard-yellow hand hovers just above it without touching. Behind them, the chalkboard equation is a soft blue blur, the same shape.

BI11BOT: Your father bet me you'd throw it in a river. I said you wouldn't.

ALEX: ...I thought about it.

**P6: The hook (short, wide)**

*Image:* A small projector unfolds from Bi11bot's shoulder with a click, and soft-blue light lands on Alex's face. His hand closes around the watch, and the rest of the room drops into shadow.

BI11BOT: Thinking about it isn't doing it. Now, shall we say hello to your father?

## Page 10: The message

**P1: The face (dominant)**

*Image:* The hologram flickers on above the workbench, its beam from Bi11bot's shoulder. Adrian looks straight at Alex, the first clear view of his face in the book. In the foreground, Alex is a frozen silhouette with his thumb over the watch's face.

ADRIAN: Hello, Alex. If you're seeing this... then you found the workshop.

**P2: Alex's face (small, silent)**

*Image:* Close on Alex. His armor is gone for a moment. His jaw is set, his eyes are bright and he isn't blinking. Soft-blue light plays across his face.

**P3: The joke (wide trio)**

*Image:* Adrian on the left with a half-smile, Alex in the centre, and Grandmother small in the background, standing in the open bookshelf doorway with warm household light behind her. One hand is at her mouth and her eyes are wet, and she is smiling. Her hands have stopped folding the cloth.

ADRIAN: Which means your grandmother still refuses to throw anything away.

GRANDMOTHER: I heard that.

**P4: What it cost (close)**

*Image:* Adrian serious now, the hologram's gold dimming toward burgundy. His eyes are steady and tired. In the background, Grandmother's hand presses to her chest.

ADRIAN: If you're watching this, I wasn't there when you needed me. I'm sorry. To you, and to Mom.

ADRIAN: I got things wrong, Alex. More than once. But every failure taught me something.

**P5: The invitation (close, fading)**

*Image:* Adrian leans slightly toward the lens. The hologram desaturates and its edges break into scan lines toward the right edge.

ADRIAN: You don't have to finish what I started. You may find a better way.

ADRIAN: Bi11bot has a map. What you do with it is up to you. And whatever he tells you... question everything. Especially me.

**P6: The photograph (short, silent)**

*Image:* The hologram is gone, and the room is back in cool blue-grey with Bi11bot's amber at the edge. Alex sits alone in the afterglow. His fingers slowly unfold the creased photograph from his jacket, and his father's face emerges from the fold, the same man he just saw. He doesn't say anything.

## Page 11: The first waypoint

**P1: Three places (dominant)**

*Image:* Bi11bot projects a large holographic map onto the workshop wall: the mountain in cross-section, Keel at the bottom, Halyard mid-slope, Oasis above the clouds. Three clearly different markers sit on it, far apart: one deep beneath Keel's pit, inside the old mine; one inside a Halyard fabrication tower; one high in Oasis. Only the Keel marker glows bright amber. The other two are dim outlines. Alex and Bi11bot are silhouetted against the light.

BI11BOT: Your father left a trail. Three artifacts, in three places.

BI11BOT: He called it the Legacy Protocol.

**P2: The Measure (close)**

*Image:* Close on the bright Keel marker, deep under the pit, at the bottom of a shaft that drops from the sealed entrance on the rim. Beside it, a small holographic label: **THE MEASURE**.

BI11BOT: The first is called the Measure. It's somewhere inside the old mine.

**P3: Sealed (medium)**

*Image:* Alex, arms crossed, lit amber, studies the sealed entrance on the map. Bi11bot beside him, head tilted.

ALEX: That mine's been sealed since before I was born.

BI11BOT: Your father knew.

ALEX: And I can't leave Keel.

BI11BOT: You don't need to. This one is under your feet.

**P4: The reason (medium)**

*Image:* Alex looks back over his shoulder toward the workbench where Adrian's hologram stood, the creased photograph in his hand. Bi11bot watches him.

ALEX: And finding it tells me what happened to him?

BI11BOT: It tells us where he wanted you to begin. The rest, we'll have to discover.

**P5: Theory and evidence (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex turns the watch over in his fingers, frowning at the caseback. Bi11bot's eye rings click as he turns to face him.

ALEX: Everyone says he gambled it all away.

BI11BOT: That's a theory. The mine is evidence.

**P6: The choice (short, close)**

*Image:* Alex's hand reaches past Bi11bot's shoulder and presses flat against the bright Measure marker, and the light ripples around his fingers. Along the old pipes at the top edge of the frame, a hairline amber pulse travels upward and out of frame.

ALEX: Then we start here.

## Page 12: Track

**P1: The climb (tall strip)**

*Image:* A vertical cutaway of the mountain's infrastructure spine, echoing Page 1. The hairline amber pulse from Page 11 travels up the water conduit from Keel. Each identical white-and-amber control node it passes flickers to full amber for an instant: first in Keel, then at the Keel–Halyard permission gate, then through Halyard, then through the cloud layer into Oasis. The strip ends at a dark window into the control room. Each tier keeps its own palette, and the pulse is the only warm color. No dialogue.

**P2: The room (wide, symmetrical)**

*Image:* A minimalist control room in Oasis, pearl white and graphite, perfectly centered. A wall-sized live display shows the mountain in cross-section, like Page 11's map but cold. Thousands of white points glow, and in Keel's dark basin one small amber point pulses. A lone seated woman, seen from behind, is

small against the display. On the desk sits a single glass of clean water, exactly aligned with the desk edge. No dialogue.

**P3: The alert (medium)**

*Image:* Close on a single monitor. Her hand hovers over two options and presses one, while the other stays dark.

*Screen text:*

LEGACY PROTOCOL DETECTED

SOURCE: KEEL SECTOR

[ REPORT ] [ **TRACK** ]

**P4: Order (small, silent)**

*Image:* Her other hand nudges the glass a few millimeters until it aligns perfectly with the desk edge and the monitor's frame.

**P5: Tracking (dominant, wide)**

*Image:* The wall display again, wider. The amber point in Keel still pulses, and a thin cold-white ring slowly closes around it. The room is reflected faintly in the display's glass, with the woman tiny at the center. The amber point is the only warm light in the room.

*Caption, in older Alex's voice, looking back:* I told myself I was only checking. Most of the true things in my life started that way.

*Lettering:* END OF CHAPTER ONE

## Chapter 2: The Price of Departure

### Page 1: The next morning

**P1: The door (wide)**

*Image:* The apartment's main room in cool grey-gold morning light, seen from the front door. Grandmother sits in her chair folding her cloth. The tall bookshelf on the right wall stands open like a door, cool blue-grey light and a small amber glow beyond it. Ada stands just inside the front door, a ration jug in one hand, frozen, staring at the shelf.

*Caption:* THE NEXT MORNING

GRANDMOTHER *(not looking up)*: He hasn't slept. Or eaten.

ADA: Alex... your bookshelf is a door.

**P2: The night he had (medium)**

*Image:* From inside the workshop, looking back at the shelf. Ada steps through with warm household light behind her. Alex sits at the worktable, hair a mess, eyes red, and completely awake: notebooks

open around him, schematics pinned to the shelves, a cold cup, the photograph of Adrian propped against a lamp, Adrian's watch in his fingers, caseback up.

ALEX: Apparently.

**P3: A second shock (tight)**

*Image:* Bi11bot's head swivels toward Ada from the shelf beside her shoulder, his brass lens ring clicking. Ada jerks back a step, jug sloshing.

BI11BOT: Good morning. You must be Ada.

ADA: There's a robot.

BI11BOT: A rather distinguished one, actually.

**P4: The decision (three-shot)**

*Image:* Bi11bot on the worktable in front, Alex behind him, Ada at the threshold. Alex looks at his father's notebooks, his private things, then at Ada. He decides.

ALEX: I haven't slept. And I think everything Keel says about my father is wrong.

ALEX: Sit down. I need someone who'll tell me when I'm wrong too.

**P5: Not alone (wide)**

*Image:* Ada takes the stool across the table. Bi11bot turns his amber gaze to them both, and warm amber edges both their shoulders.

BI11BOT: Your father didn't work alone either. The people he trusted made all the difference.

BI11BOT: It begins with the wars.

## Page 2: What Alpha is

**P1: The wars (wide)**

*Image:* A hologram fills the workshop above the worktable. Simple fractured scenes: a reservoir dried to cracked mud, a guarded storehouse, families walking with jugs. To the right the fragments draw together into the mountain of three cities. Alex, Ada and Bi11bot are small silhouettes at the bottom.

*Caption:* AFTER THE WATER WARS, THREE CITIES REMAINED.

BI11BOT: After the Water Wars, the cities couldn't agree on how to share what was left.

**P2: Built for the emergency (medium)**

*Image:* In the hologram, three groups of exhausted delegates, one from each city, sit at a single table. Above them, a small white ring with an amber point switches on for the first time.

BI11BOT: So an emergency council of all three built Alpha, an AI to run the emergency. Water, food, power, work, travel.

ALEX: They put an AI in charge of people's lives?

**P3: The question (two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada and Bi11bot. Ada's eyes are on the symbol, her thumb stopped on a rivet of her strap. Bi11bot's lens clicks.

ADA: Who gave it that authority?

BI11BOT: People who were afraid. Reasonably so. It was meant to be temporary.

**P4: It stayed (dominant)**

*Image:* A high angle. The delegates' table in the hologram fades away chair by chair until only the white-and-amber symbol remains, larger now, five streams of light flowing into it. The three figures are small below. The amber point is the only warm spot in the room.

ALEX: What happened?

BI11BOT: The emergency ended. Alpha's authority didn't.

**P5: The split (wide)**

*Image:* The hologram divides into three levels. Oasis: full reservoirs, fountains. Halyard: busy workshops and trains. Keel: one dripping tap and a queue. Each level wears the same small node.

BI11BOT: It isn't cruel. It keeps things stable. But nobody it decides for can vote it out.

**P6: Safer for whom (close)**

*Image:* Alex studies Keel's level of the hologram, arms crossed, its blue-grey light on his face.

ALEX: Stable for whom?

BI11BOT *(small balloon, off-panel)*: Your father asked that too.

## Page 3: Three safeguards

**P1: The three (wide)**

*Image:* Three objects rotate above Adrian's worktable in soft blue hologram, each clearly different in shape and colour. Adrian's handwritten notes orbit them in gold. Adrian himself is not in the room, only his handwriting. Bi11bot stands on the table presenting; Alex and Ada watch.

BI11BOT: When Alpha was built, the council wrote a way to take its power back. Then everyone forgot it was there.

BI11BOT: Your father found it. And built the three things it needs.

**P2: The Measure (triptych)**

*Image:* Close on the Measure, turning slowly. Behind it, two gauges side by side, showing different readings.

*Caption:* THE MEASURE

BI11BOT: It shows you what's really happening, and what's being hidden.

**P3: The Maker's Seal (triptych)**

*Image:* Close on the Maker's Seal. Behind it, a simple tool and the hand that made it, joined by a thin line of light.

*Caption:* THE MAKER'S SEAL

BI11BOT: It proves who made something, and who it belongs to.

**P4: The Covenant (triptych)**

*Image:* Close on the Covenant. Behind it, several hands, each touching one part of it.

*Caption:* THE COVENANT

BI11BOT: It proves people agreed to the rules, and can hold each other to them.

**P5: Together (dominant)**

*Image:* Top-down on the hologram. The three artifacts form a triangle around Alpha's symbol. Under the symbol, a faint old lattice, dark and dusty, with three empty sockets at the triangle's points.

ALEX: So if we find all three, we shut Alpha down?

BI11BOT: No. The lights stay on. The pumps keep running. Alpha stays a tool.

BI11BOT: What ends is its right to decide for everyone.

**P6: Who decides (two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada leaning in. Alex picks up the watch from the table.

ADA: And who decides instead?

BI11BOT: People. That's what the Covenant is for.

ALEX: And if I just carry them up the mountain?

BI11BOT: Then you're a boy with three heavy objects. Somebody has to use them, on purpose, and answer for it.

## Page 4: Both were true

**P1: The recording (wide)**

*Image:* The Last Chance years ago, rust-amber lights, a busy floor. At a corner table, Adrian fills a napkin with branching sums and watches the players' faces, not the cards. A small stack of credit slips sits at his elbow. At the door, a young bouncer, the man from Chapter One's Page 2, watches Adrian.

*Caption:* THE LAST CHANCE, YEARS BEFORE

BI11BOT: He watched people decide with their own money on the line. When the odds are bad, why do they still choose?

**P2: The watch (strip)**

*Image:* Alex holds the watch beside the hologram, caseback out. The looping equation engraved on it matches a looping equation floating in the air.

ALEX: That's on my watch.

BI11BOT: That's his equation.

**P3: The missing part (dominant)**

*Image:* A high-angle hologram of the equation over the worktable, large and beautiful, most of its terms glowing steady gold. One term at its heart stays open, a bright empty loop that won't resolve. Alpha's symbol sits outside it, looking in. The three figures are small below.

ALEX: What's the part that won't solve?

BI11BOT: Human choice. He spent years trying to model it. He never could.

**P4: Estimate, not decide (two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada and Alex across the hologram, faces in gold.

ADA: Because people do things when they can't know how they'll turn out.

BI11BOT: Alpha can estimate what people might do. Adrian believed it should never decide what they must do.

ALEX: And the safeguards?

BI11BOT: They only work for people who look, choose, and live with what happens next.

**P5: The debt (close)**

*Image:* Alex looks at the watch, then up. Bi11bot's hologram behind him shows a stack of loan papers beside a stack of patent drawings, the two piles roughly the same height.

ALEX: So the debt wasn't from gambling.

BI11BOT: Some was. Most was money he borrowed to pay for his research. The work never paid him back.

ALEX: Or someone made sure it couldn't.

**P6: Grandmother (strip)**

*Image:* Through the open shelf, Grandmother in her chair, folding, half-listening.

GRANDMOTHER: I told you he was working.

BI11BOT *(small)*: She's half right. Both were true.

## Page 5: The cost of a plan

**P1: The table (wide)**

*Image:* The kitchen table. Adrian's paper map of the mine is spread out. Alex, Ada and Bi11bot lean over it. Grandmother sits nearby. The workshop glows through the open shelf.

*Caption:* LATER THAT MORNING

ALEX: First the Measure. Then Halyard, for the Maker's Seal.

ADA: The old mine entrance on the rim is sealed. How do you get in?

**P2: The way in (close)**

*Image:* Alex's finger on the paper map, tracing from the active mine, SITE 6, along a tunnel to a barred door marked in Adrian's hand: OLD WORKS.

ALEX: Through the active mine. I work Site 6. The old works are behind it.

BI11BOT: Getting into Site 6 is easy. Getting past it is another matter.

**P3: Ada's map (two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada has been copying the map by hand into her own notebook. She tears the page out: the tunnels redrawn, a small inked pipe at the third junction, where Adrian's map shows only a wall.

ADA: His old plans show a pipe behind that wall. His map doesn't. Take mine.

ALEX: Which one's right?

ADA: Find out.

**P4: What it costs (top-down)**

*Image:* Alex empties his credit card onto the table as a small glowing pile: 52. Around it, four simple labelled spaces: MEDICINE 30, FOOD 10, RAIL FARE 25, and, off to one side and far larger, a red tag from his wristband: OVERDUE 500.

*Wristband:* DEBT 418,607 CR / OVERDUE 500 CR / TRAVEL: RESTRICTED UNTIL OVERDUE IS PAID

ADA: Fifty-two. And you can't leave Keel until the five hundred's paid.

ALEX: Then I'm not leaving yet.

**P5: Medicine first (close)**

*Image:* Alex's hand slides thirty credits into the MEDICINE space. The knock of the front door: NELL, the downstairs neighbour (a broad woman in her sixties with short grey hair and a white clinic smock), at the door with Grandmother's medicine bag.

NELL: Thirty for the week, love. Same as always.

ALEX: Same as always.

**P6: The echo (short)**

*Image:* Tight on Grandmother's face, eyes steady and clear. Behind her Alex zips his tool bag, Bi11bot folding himself inside it.

ALEX: One shift. Then we'll see.

GRANDMOTHER: Your father said that once.

## Page 6: Site 6 and the snap

**P1: Site 6 (wide)**

*Image:* A cavernous active mine in dim work light: a conveyor, a hauling frame, workers passing a gate. Far down a side tunnel, a faded sign reads OLD WORKS — CLOSED above a heavy iron door. Alex is small at the gate.

*Caption:* KEEL EXTRACTION SITE 6

**P2: The gate (medium)**

*Image:* Alex's hand on the scanner. Foreman-7, the site foreman, watches, a white-and-amber node on his chest. Behind Alex in the queue, an older miner's head lifts at the name.

FOREMAN-7: Worker Phantum. Bay 6.

ALEX: Same bay as always.

**P3: Scrap (tight)**

*Image:* Inside the tool bag, between wrenches, one warm amber eye peers out from a folded Bi11bot.

BI11BOT *(whispering)*: Brass and no registration. I read as scrap.

ALEX *(under his breath)*: Then look like scrap.

**P4: Watched (medium)**

*Image:* Bay 6, near the side tunnel. Alex works at a hauling frame, eyes on the iron door at the far end. A few feet away the older miner, TOMAS, watches Alex a beat too long. On Tomas's wrist guard, a carved water-drop.

BI11BOT *(from the bag)*: Patience. Something usually moves.

ALEX: Something usually breaks.

**P5: The snap (dominant)**

*Image:* A support cable whips loose with a crack, and the hauling frame drops. Tomas is pinned beneath it. Workers freeze. In the background, the side tunnel is empty and the iron door unwatched.

*SFX:* SNAP! CRASH!

**P6: The choice (short)**

*Image:* Low and tight. Alex's boots start toward the side tunnel, then turn. His wristband flashes cold white as he crosses the yellow line toward Tomas.

*Wristband:* LEFT ASSIGNED ZONE — TODAY'S WAGE FORFEITED: −40 CR

*Caption, older Alex:* I'd like to say I thought about it. I didn't.

## Page 7: The old key

**P1: The frame (wide)**

*Image:* Dust in the air. Alex levers the hauling frame with a length of pipe, boot braced. Tomas slides free. Workers watch from behind the line; Foreman-7 strides toward them from far off.

ALEX: Don't move.

TOMAS: Wasn't planning to.

**P2: Bi11 (tight)**

*Image:* Tomas sits against the wall, leg bruised. The tool bag has tipped open and Bi11bot's amber eye looks out. Amber light finds Tomas's face, and his eyes widen.

TOMAS: Bi11...?

ALEX: You know him?

TOMAS: Your father carried him everywhere. I knew Adrian Phantum.

**P3: Who Adrian was (medium)**

*Image:* Tomas pushes his sleeve up to show the carved water-drop on his wrist guard. Behind him, simple and faint, a memory: a younger Tomas and Adrian side by side at a broken pump, sleeves rolled up.

TOMAS: Twenty years ago we fixed the pumps on this level together. He paid for the parts himself.

TOMAS: Not the man on the casino wall. The one who came down here and asked what we needed.

**P4: The door he kept (close)**

*Image:* Tomas nods toward the iron door at the end of the side tunnel.

TOMAS: Before he left, he asked me to keep that door. Oil the lock. Tell nobody. Wait for whoever came with Bi11.

ALEX: What's behind it?

TOMAS: I never asked.

**P5: Why me (dominant)**

*Image:* A close two-shot, Tomas warm in amber light, Alex wary. In soft focus behind them, Foreman-7's cold node grows larger.

ALEX: Why trust me? You don't know me.

TOMAS: You stopped for a stranger. He said that's how I'd know it was you.

**P6: The plan (strip)**

*Image:* Tomas's hand on an orange emergency lever on the wall, his eyes on Alex.

TOMAS: Go stand by that door. When I pull this, go.

## Page 8: The door

**P1: The lever (dominant)**

*Image:* Tomas pulls the emergency lever. Alarms, orange strobes, white mist billowing across the bay. Workers move to the exits as drilled. Foreman-7 turns toward Tomas.

*SFX:* WHOOP! WHOOP!

**P2: The key (small)**

*Image:* Tomas presses a heavy, long, hand-cut metal key into Alex's palm. The equation's loop is stamped on its head.

TOMAS: Old lock. No wires. Alpha doesn't know it's there.

**P3: Come with us (small)**

*Image:* Alex's hand closes on the key, his eyes on Tomas.

ALEX: Come with us.

TOMAS: Somebody has to take the blame for the button.

**P4: The cost (strip)**

*Image:* Tomas limps into the mist toward Foreman-7, his body between the robot and the side tunnel.

TOMAS *(shouting)*: Foreman! Wrong lever! My fault!

**P5: The route (wide)**

*Image:* A clear side view: the bay, the mist, Tomas and Foreman-7 at left; the side tunnel running right; Alex at the iron door at the far right end, key in the lock, Bi11bot on his shoulder.

**P6: Cold (extreme close-up)**

*Image:* Alex's palm flat on the iron door. It's beaded with water.

ALEX: It's wet.

BI11BOT: Closed mines are dry. Something in there isn't closed.

**P7: Gone (low, from inside)**

*Image:* The door swings shut. Alex and Bi11bot in the dark beyond, half of Alex's face in amber. Through the last sliver, Tomas facing Foreman-7.

*SFX:* CLUNK

## Page 9: Inside the error

**P1: The old works (dominant)**

*Image:* The old works in Bi11bot's amber light: rusted rails, collapsed timber supports, dead machines furred with dust. Everything is brown and still. Alex holds a work lamp and Ada's page.

ALEX: Nobody's been here in years.

**P2: New bolts (extreme close-up)**

*Image:* Alex's lamp on a pipe bracket on the left wall. Among rusted timbers, the bracket is clean, its bolts bright and new, its paint fresh.

ALEX: Hold on. These bolts are new.

BI11BOT: Then someone has been looking after something.

**P3: The pipe on her page (two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex holds Ada's page against the wall. Her small inked pipe sits at this junction. Under his fingers the wall is beaded with condensation, and through a gap in the rock a thick pipe runs, sweating, that appears on her page and not on Adrian's map.

ALEX: Ada drew a pipe here. And here it is.

**P4: The light (high angle)**

*Image:* A security drone's cold white searchlight sweeps down the main tunnel. Alex and Bi11bot pressed flat in the narrow side passage beside the pipe as the beam passes the wrong way.

**P5: Ada, waiting (inset, silent)**

*Image:* Ada at Alex's kitchen table, her copy of the map under both hands, staring at the door. Grandmother folds her cloth beside her. She can't reach him and doesn't know if she was right.

**P6: Follow it (strip)**

*Image:* Alex and Bi11bot in silhouette follow the sweating pipe along a narrow passage toward a slit of blue-white light. No dialogue.

## Page 10: The lie

**P1: The chamber (wide)**

*Image:* A hidden chamber inside the abandoned mine, tall and clean, lit blue-white. Pipes come down from the mountain into one big junction. Out of it run two pipes. One is narrow and old, stencilled KEEL HOMES. One is broad and new, stencilled UPLINK INDUSTRIAL, climbing back up the mountain. Between them, a big official gauge. Alex and Bi11bot are small at the threshold.

ALEX: This isn't abandoned.

BI11BOT: Only the mine around it is.

**P2: The official number (medium)**

*Image:* The gauge, large and clear, with Alpha's white-and-amber node on its casing. One bold needle on a dial labelled KEEL'S SHARE OF THIS JUNCTION.

*Gauge:* KEEL'S SHARE: 62%

ALEX: The official gauge says Keel gets most of the water through here.

**P3: Two pipes (split frame)**

*Image:* Left: Alex's palm on the KEEL HOMES pipe, cold and still, a single bead of water. Right: his other palm on the UPLINK pipe, trembling with motion lines, water roaring inside.

ALEX: Then why is our pipe barely moving?

BI11BOT: Either the records are wrong, or someone is making sure they look right.

**P4: The equation (tight)**

*Image:* On a small service panel under the gauge, scratched into the metal, the looping equation from the watch's caseback. Alex holds the watch up beside it, caseback out. They match.

ALEX: That's Dad's equation. He found this.

**P5: Hidden behind the gauge (medium)**

*Image:* Alex opens the service panel. Inside, wedged behind the gauge's wiring, the Measure.

BI11BOT: For years, everyone trusted Alpha's numbers. Nobody could check them.

BI11BOT: He left you a way to check.

**P6: The Measure (dominant)**

*Image:* A low-angle wide shot. Alex lifts the Measure out into the blue-white light, holding it in both hands. Bi11bot beside him, amber at the edge of the frame.

*Caption, older Alex:* I'd spent my whole life being told what was true. This was the first time I could look.

## Page 11: Two paths

**P1: What's moving (medium)**

*Image:* Alex clamps the Measure to the KEEL HOMES pipe. A simple readout blooms above it: a thin trickle of blue.

*Readout:* KEEL HOMES: 18% OF THIS JUNCTION

**P2: What's reported (strip)**

*Image:* Bi11bot touches the gauge's cable; the gauge's 62% appears in the readout beside the Measure's 18%. Two bars, one tall, one short.

*Readout:* REPORTED 62% / DELIVERED 18%

**P3: Where it goes (dominant)**

*Image:* The water reveal fills the page. The Measure throws a huge map of the mountain's pipes into the air: a thin rust-orange thread for Keel, and beside it a wide bright-blue river of water running from the junction up through the UPLINK pipe, toward Halyard's factories and Oasis's fountains. Alex and Ada's whole city is the thin thread. Alex and Bi11bot are tiny beneath it.

ALEX: Most of Keel's water goes back up the mountain.

**P4: The choice (two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex and Bi11bot under the map, the Measure between them.

BI11BOT: We have the proof. Now you have a choice.

BI11BOT: Take the Measure and leave quietly. Nobody learns what we found. You go on to Halyard.

BI11BOT: Or send this to every screen in Keel. Alpha will know exactly where it came from.

**P5: The weighing (tight)**

*Image:* Alex's face, half blue, half amber. In his eyes, small, the thin orange thread.

ALEX: And come looking for me.

BI11BOT: Yes.

ALEX: Ada rations her water. Grandma counts every jug.

**P6: Someone has to (low angle)**

*Image:* Alex's hand on the Measure. Bi11bot watching him, not deciding.

ALEX: Then everyone needs to see it.

## Page 12: Truth belongs to everyone

**P1: Send (strip)**

*Image:* Alex's thumb presses the Measure's one button, firmly, on purpose. The two bars and the map lift off it as light and run into the gauge's cable.

*SFX:* CLICK

ALEX: Send it.

**P2: Everywhere at once (dominant, multi-location)**

*Image:* One wide panel of five simple vignettes, all switching in the same instant: a ration station queue, a household wall screen, a tram stop board, a mine-shift display, a street kiosk. Ordinary Keel faces look up, mid-motion.

*Screen text, identical on every screen:*

KEEL'S SHARE OF THE JUNCTION

REPORTED: 62% — DELIVERED: 18%

WHERE THE REST GOES: [map of the Uplink pipe]

**P3: Reading it (strip, three faces)**

*Image:* Three Keel faces in a row, reading: a woman with an empty jug; a boy at the ration queue; Nell (broad, sixties, short grey hair, white clinic smock) at Alex's building's door.

WOMAN WITH JUG: Eighteen.

BOY: That's not a mistake. That's a pipe.

**P4: Nothing flows yet (medium)**

*Image:* Back in the chamber. The KEEL HOMES pipe is exactly as still as before. Only the information has moved.

BI11BOT: The water hasn't changed. Only what people know.

ALEX: That's a start.

**P5: Found (tight)**

*Image:* Alex's wristband lights cold white.

*Wristband:* SOURCE IDENTIFIED: ALEX PHANTUM / LOCATION: OLD WORKS, SITE 6 / REMAIN IN PLACE

**P6: Footsteps (wide)**

*Image:* The chamber door. Cold white light and the heavy tread of Foreman-7 approaching down the passage. Alex doesn't step back.

FOREMAN-7 *(off-panel)*: Worker Phantum. Remain in place.

## Page 13: What Keel gives back

**P1: Not alone (wide)**

*Image:* From behind Alex and Bi11bot, looking out the chamber door. Foreman-7 fills the doorway, but behind him the passage is packed with miners in work lamps, Tomas at the front, leg bandaged.

TOMAS: We saw the numbers, Foreman.

FOREMAN-7: Obstructing Alpha's officer is an offence.

TOMAS: Then it's all of ours.

**P2: Held ground (medium)**

*Image:* Miners step between Foreman-7 and Alex, a calm line of people. Foreman-7's optics flick across them, counting. It stops.

**P3: The valve, carefully (wide)**

*Image:* Tomas and two pump workers at the junction's manual valve, one reading a pressure gauge, one with a hand raised for "slowly." They turn the wheel a quarter turn. The KEEL HOMES pipe begins, gently, to hum.

TOMAS: Quarter turn. Watch the old joints.

PUMP WORKER: Holding. Another quarter.

**P4: The first jug (small)**

*Image:* A Keel street tap. A woman's jug fills a little faster than it did yesterday. She looks up.

**P5: What a city gives (wide, multi-vignette)**

*Image:* Simple warm vignettes across Keel: a vendor filling a sack with dried food; a mechanic handing over a lamp and a rope; at the ration station, a line of people each tapping their wristbands on a public terminal under Alex's name. Ada is at the terminal, clearly organizing, a paper list in her hand.

*Terminal:* PAYMENT TO: ALEX PHANTUM, OVERDUE BALANCE / FROM 61 ACCOUNTS

ADA: Five each, or two, or one. Whatever you can.

MECHANIC: He fixed my pump for nothing last winter.

**P6: Why (strip)**

*Image:* Alex, walking out of the mine with Tomas, the Measure in his hand.

ALEX: Why are they doing this?

TOMAS: You stopped for us first.

## Page 14: Goodbye

**P1: Home (wide)**

*Image:* Alex comes through the front door. Ada at the table, cinching two packs: food, lamp, rope, the paper map. Grandmother in her chair. Nell (broad, sixties, short grey hair, white clinic smock) sits beside her with the medicine bag and a list.

ADA: You're late.

ALEX: I had company.

**P2: The wristband (tight)**

*Image:* Close on Alex's wristband.

*Wristband:* DEBT 418,107 CR / OVERDUE 0 CR / TRAVEL: PERMITTED

ALEX: Five hundred. From people who don't have five hundred.

ADA: The other four hundred and eighteen thousand are still yours.

**P3: Who stays (two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex looks at Grandmother, then at Nell.

ALEX: I can't leave her alone.

NELL: You're not. I'm moving in upstairs. Medicine's paid through the month. I'll do her mornings and nights.

**P4: Kneeling (dominant)**

*Image:* Alex kneels at Grandmother's chair, at her eye level, as on Page 5 of Chapter One. Her hands are still, the cloth resting in her lap.

GRANDMOTHER: I always told you he was working. Nobody believes an old woman.

ALEX: I believed you. I just didn't know it yet.

GRANDMOTHER: Go. You've lived long enough inside his unfinished story.

**P5: The promise (medium)**

*Image:* Grandmother takes Alex's face in both hands, steady, her eyes clear.

ALEX *(quiet)*: I'll come back for you.

GRANDMOTHER: I know.

**P6: Why she's coming (two-shot, threshold)**

*Image:* Ada at the open door, pack on her shoulder.

ALEX: What about Keel? You wanted to fix it, not leave it.

ADA: I'm not leaving Keel behind. I'm going to find out who decided it had to stay this way.

**P7: Out (wide, from outside)**

*Image:* From the street. Alex, Ada and Bi11bot step out. Grandmother and Nell are small warm shapes in the doorway, Grandmother's hand raised.

## Page 15: The train

**P1: The gate (wide)**

*Image:* The Keel–Halyard permission gate across the rail line, the one from Chapter One's Page 1. Alex holds his wristband to the scanner. Ada beside him. Steam and work-lamp light.

*Scanner:* ALEX PHANTUM — TRAVEL PERMITTED

*SFX:* CLUNK

**P2: Leaving (dominant)**

*Image:* Inside the old train car, warm and nearly empty. Alex by the window, Ada beside him, Bi11bot on the seat between them. Outside, Keel's basin slides past: the pit rim, the mine, and a street tap where a queue is shorter than it was this morning.

*Caption, older Alex:* I went into the mine to get out of Keel. I came out owing it.

**P3: One down (close two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada holds up the Measure between them, grinning for the first time in the chapter.

ADA: We have the Measure. One down.

ALEX: Two to go. The Maker's Seal is next.

**P4: The clue (tight)**

*Image:* Bi11bot's chest projects a short note in Adrian's handwriting that wasn't readable before, now unlocked, glowing gold.

BI11BOT: It opened after you sent the proof. He left it for whoever used the Measure.

*Note:* HALYARD PATENT REGISTRY. My work is filed under my name. The people who made it with me are not. Find them. — A.

**P5: Rising (window shot)**

*Image:* Through the window, Halyard climbs into view: bronze and gold workshops, greenhouse terraces, the three Charter House towers. Alex's reflection faint over it, Keel's rust colours falling away below.

ALEX: Then that's where we start.

**P6: The follower (tight, cold)**

*Image:* Several rows back, unseen by them, a passenger's gloved hand rests on a small device below the seatback. A cold pearl-graphite readout glows against their palm.

*Screen:* THE BOY HAS THE MEASURE.

*Reply:* FOLLOW. DO NOT TAKE IT YET.

*Lettering:* END OF CHAPTER TWO

## Chapter 3: The Price of Ownership

### Page 1: The city of makers

**P1: Arrival (dominant)**

*Image:* Halyard at sunrise, seen from the train platform. Suspended rail lines cross between glass laboratories, fabrication towers, vertical farms and foundries. Three illuminated House insignias, each in its own accent color, dominate three separate skyline clusters. Below the towers, workers stream through gated checkpoints in House-colored uniforms. Alex, Ada and Bi11bot are small in the foreground, stepping off the train.

**P2: Three houses (wide)**

*Image:* Inside a crowded transit concourse. Three huge holographic ads compete overhead, each in its House's accent color: Calder shows clean rivers and atmospheric water towers, Ivers shows fusion grids and compute centers, Steyn shows orbital stations and advanced materials. Each features a founder's face and a shared slogan.

*Ad slogan:* CREATION REQUIRES SCALE. SCALE REQUIRES ORDER.

ADA: Three families run almost everything here.

ALEX: Alpha allowed that?

BI11BOT: Allowed it. Recommended it.

**P3: Fewer questions (street level)**

*Image:* Street level beneath the towers. Workers queue at a contribution kiosk, visibly more orderly and better-dressed than Keel, but still queuing. A faded old sign over a shuttered independent workshop reads MORROW & SONS — INVENTORS SINCE 2024, a House insignia stamped crudely over the original name.

ADA: Why recommend it?

BI11BOT: Efficiency. Less duplication, less risk.

BI11BOT: Also fewer people asking who owns what.

**P4: The kiosk (medium)**

*Image:* A young engineer feeds a small mechanical component into a scanner. Alex and Ada watch from a few feet away.

*Screen:* CONTRIBUTION ACCEPTED / OWNERSHIP: HOUSE IVERS / CREATOR BONUS: 14 CREDITS

ALEX: She invented it. Why doesn't she start a business?

BI11BOT: She could try. But the Houses control the factories, distribution networks, and nearly every license.

ADA: So she has the freedom to invent. Just not the freedom to compete?

BI11BOT: Precisely.

**P5: What she keeps (close)**

*Image:* Close on the engineer's face as she steps away from the kiosk, unbothered, well paid and good at her job, already moving to the next task. Behind her, the shuttered Morrow & Sons sign from P3 is visible, slightly out of focus.

ALEX: And if she leaves?

BI11BOT: She keeps the experience. That’s about it.

## Page 2: The estate

**P1: The hall (wide)**

*Image:* A vast registry hall, rows of vertical glass screens stretching up into shadow, filled with scrolling patents, ownership records and commercial licenses. Alex, Ada and Bi11bot are small, dwarfed by scale for the first time since the mountain on Page 1 of Chapter One. A line of workers waits at public terminals.

*Caption:* THE HALYARD PUBLIC REGISTRY

**P2: The flood (dominant)**

*Image:* Alex holds his identity band near a terminal. The screen freezes for a beat, then floods upward with data, the camera's angle tilting with it. A cold white alert overlay cuts across the warm gold data behind it.

*Screen:* PHANTUM, ADRIAN / INTELLECTUAL ESTATE: ACTIVE / CLAIMANT DETECTED: ALEX PHANTUM / 312 PATENTS — 47 RESTRICTED — 19 DISPUTED

ALEX: Three hundred and twelve?

**P3: Badly labeled (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada and Alex side by side, both staring up at the screen. Bi11bot watches Alex's face rather than the data.

ADA: You said your father left you nothing.

ALEX: He left me debt.

BI11BOT: Your father left many things. Badly labeled.

**P4: The term (close)**

*Image:* Close on the screen's lower text, Alex's reflection faint over it.

*Screen:* CHARTER HOUSE REVIEW REQUIRED

ALEX: What does "intellectual estate" mean?

**P5: Whatever he made (close)**

*Image:* Close on Ada, her eyes narrowing as she reads ahead of him.

ADA: It means whatever he made might now belong to you. He never worked for the Houses. Or he never let them know he did.

**P6: Watched (strip)**

*Image:* Wide and low, from across the hall. Several sharply dressed figures in mixed House colors have turned to look toward Alex's terminal, unhurried, already moving his way. Security drones hover at a respectful distance, their lights cold white.

## Page 3: The offer

**P1: The approach (wide)**

*Image:* Lock crosses the hall at an unhurried pace, flanked loosely by two aides in mixed House colors, drones trailing at a respectful distance. He is composed, silver-templed, dressed in charcoal and platinum with no House crest.

*Caption:* DIRECTOR LOCK

**P2: Waiting for an heir (dominant)**

*Image:* Lock stops a few feet from Alex, unthreatening, hands loosely clasped. Behind him, Adrian's estate record still glows cold white on the terminal.

LOCK: Alex Phantum. Welcome! Halyard has been waiting a long time for an heir.

ALEX: It’s been kinda tough to get away from the grind in Keel….

LOCK: Then today is your lucky day..

**P3: The gesture (two-shot)**

*Image:* Lock gestures toward the glowing patent record without looking at it, his eyes staying on Alex.

LOCK: Your father's work could clear every debt attached to your name.  I’m willing to take that risk.

LOCK: It could also secure you a position. Somewhere in Halyard that suits you.  I’m sure you won’t miss Keel.

**P4: In exchange (close)**

*Image:* Ada steps half in front of Alex, arms crossed, watching Lock's hands, not his face.

ADA: In exchange for what?

LOCK: A simple assignment of rights.

LOCK: You sign. The estate transfers to our House. We pay back Alpha.. Your name and debt is clear by tonight.

**P5: Simple (close)**

*Image:* Close on Lock's calm, patient expression, utterly sincere.

LOCK: Your father was a brilliant inventor. But an invention isn't a business.

ALEX: And the Houses can make it one?

LOCK: We have the capital, factories, engineers, and customers. We can take discoveries from a workshop to the entire city.

ALEX: And if someone wants to build something different?

LOCK: They're welcome to try. But scale is what makes innovation useful.

**P6: No answer yet (wide)**

*Image:* Lock inclines his head, unbothered by silence, and steps back, his aides falling in behind him.

LOCK: Take the day to think about it. Halyard isn't going anywhere.

*(He leaves. Alex doesn't move. Bi11bot's amber eye tracks him out of the hall.)*

## Page 4: What he built with others

**P1: The room (wide)**

*Image:* A small rented room above a maker district, the noise of the street dulled by thin walls, a single window showing Halyard's towers at dusk. Alex sits on the edge of a narrow bed, his thumb rubbing the face of Adrian's old steel watch on his left wrist, Adrian's smoothed photograph propped against a lamp as it was in Chapter One. Ada stands at the window, arms crossed, watching the towers. Bi11bot waits on the table, unlit.

*Caption:* THAT EVENING

**P2: Not yet (strip)**

*Image:* Close on Alex's hand, hovering near his identity band, not touching it.

ADA: You're thinking about it.

ALEX: I'm thinking.

**P3: The archive (dominant)**

*Image:* Bi11bot projects Adrian's patent archive across the bare walls, filling the small room with soft blue light. Most files sit encrypted or fragmented, grey and inert. One cluster glows differently, warmer, more defined: a series of water-related patents connected by incomplete diagrams, catalytic membrane purification, atmospheric moisture capture, mineral recovery, living biofilter regulation, distributed community water nodes. At the cluster's center, faint but unmistakable, the bronze open-hand symbol of the Maker's Seal pulses once.

BI11BOT: All these patents provide different value.  Your father expected someone to come looking.  One will lead us to the Makers Seal.

ALEX: Three hundred and twelve patents. How do we know which one leads to the Seal?

BI11BOT: Because your father marked this one.

ADA: Can you open it?

BI11BOT: Part of it. But four collaborators hold the missing pieces.

ALEX: Well, let’s start with this one and see if these patents are really worth anything.

**P4: More water (strip)**

*Image:* Alex's identity band buzzes. A message from Tomas opens above it: a photo of a jug of cloudy water under a Keel tap. Alex holds the Measure up to the photo's readings, and a small readout blooms beside it.

*Message:* TOMAS: More water. Look at it.

*Readout:* METALS: OLD PIPE CORROSION / MINE RUNOFF

ALEX: I thought the Measure fixed it.

ADA: The Measure provides transparency.  It doesn’t clean dirty water.  .

**P5: Four names (medium)**

*Image:* Four flat, official identification portraits resolve from the projection, each beneath a small House insignia in its accent color: two under Calder's jade-teal, one under Steyn's steel-violet, one under Ivers's amber-orange.

BI11BOT: He built them with others.

ALEX: They're all inside the Houses.

BI11BOT: Exactly where Halyard puts everyone useful.

ALEX: So finding them brings us closer to the Seal?

BI11BOT: And may finally discover the real value of his inventions.

**P6: What it would take (medium)**

*Image:* Alex looks from the patent cluster to the four portraits, doing the sum in his head.

ALEX: All those patents should be worth a fortune.

BI11BOT: Potentially. But a patent isn't a product. And a product isn't necessarily a profitable business.

ADA: So what would it take?

BI11BOT: The right people, working technology, time, equipment…and more money than you currently have.

**P7: Not nothing (strip)**

*Image:* Alex looks at the four portraits, then at Lock's registry alert still faintly visible as a cold white afterimage at the edge of the projection, the two options sitting side by side in the same room.

ALEX: Lock's offer clears this by tonight. This takes... what, weeks?

BI11BOT: Lock's offer clears the debt. It doesn't clear anything else.

## Page 5: Lina Vey

**P1: The facility (wide)**

*Image:* A vast Calder purification facility, rows of enormous processing columns and channels. Workers in Calder jade-teal uniforms move between stations. Alex, Ada and Bi11bot approach a stooped woman in a maintenance-grade uniform despite the authority in her bearing.

**P2: Frequently (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Lina looks Alex over, unimpressed, arms crossed.

LINA: Adrian Phantum's son.

ALEX: You knew him?

LINA: I corrected him. Frequently.

BI11BOT: Nearly continuously.

LINA: You think he left this to you? *(She nods at the erased names still visible faintly in Bi11bot's projection.)* He left it to all of us.

**P3: The failing river (dominant)**

*Image:* Lina leads them to a wide observation window over a contaminated feeder channel, visibly fouled with mineral runoff and industrial residue, flowing out toward the mountain and down toward Keel. A cold white alert glows on the glass.

*Screen:* DOWNSTREAM PURIFICATION FAILURE / PROJECTED IMPACT: KEEL WATER NETWORK

LINA: That river feeds what's left of Keel's supply. Calder can clean sections of it. Not fast enough, and not without shutting down half the production district.

ALEX: We just got Keel's water flowing again.

LINA: Getting more water to Keel doesn't make it safe.

**P4: Every piece (medium)**

*Image:* Lina gestures up at the Calder insignia glowing above the facility floor, her expression dry.

ALEX: Adrian's patents could fix it?

LINA: Combined correctly, they'd purify the flow and recover what's contaminating it.

LINA: Every division has a piece of the solution. But nobody gets rewarded for helping another division succeed.

ALEX: Even if it means solving the problem?

LINA: Especially if it threatens something they're already selling.  They call it the innovator’s dilemma.

**P5: Off the system (strip)**

*Image:* Close on Lina's hand pressing an old physical data shard into a slot on Bi11bot's chest. A section of the purification design blooms in his projection, a flexible membrane diagram, with the bronze

Maker's Seal symbol flashing briefly inside it. Around the symbol, five empty positions form a ring, one for each person who built the design. The first one fills.

LINA: He made each of us keep one piece off the system. He worried Halyard would confuse protecting an idea with owning the person who had it.

ALEX: Will you help us find the other three?

LINA: *(already walking)* Try keeping up this time.

## Page 6: Suri Anik

**P1: The wing (wide)**

*Image:* A biofilter research wing, living walls of root systems and algae columns glowing warm green, in sharp visual contrast to the industrial channels of Page 5. Lina leads Alex, Ada and Bi11bot through it without slowing down. A younger woman in a research coat works alone at a terminal, cross-checking samples no one else seems to be reviewing.

**P2: What Ada sees (dominant)**

*Image:* Ada's eyes go first to the empty workstations around Suri, not to Suri herself, counting them. Suri hasn't looked up yet.

ADA *(quiet, to Alex)*: She's the only one still working this bench.

**P3: Introductions (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Suri finally looks up, recognizing Lina first, then studying Alex's face for Adrian in it.

SURI: Lina said you might come. I didn't believe her.

ALEX: Why not?

SURI: Because the ones who come looking for Adrian usually want what he built. Not who he built it with.

**P4: The piece (close)**

*Image:* Suri unlocks a small case beneath her station and hands over a second physical shard, worn smooth from handling. In Bi11bot's projection, a second position around the Seal symbol fills.

SURI: My biofilter uses living organisms to clean contaminated water. Get the conditions wrong, and the whole system collapses.

BI11BOT: Which is why Adrian trusted you to keep experimenting.

**P5: Why she stayed (close)**

*Image:* Suri closes the case, her expression unreadable.

ADA: Where's the rest of your team?

SURI: Moved on. Different projects. Better chances of getting promoted.

ALEX: And you stayed?

SURI: Because I think this works. I just haven't found the missing piece yet.

**P6: Watched (wide, closing strip)**

*Image:* As the group leaves the wing, a small overhead sensor swivels to track them, its light a cold, unmistakable white against the warm green. No one in the panel notices it.

## Page 7: Jalen Orr

**P1: The core (wide)**

*Image:* A cavernous Ivers compute core, towering server racks and glowing conduits stretching up into haze, the air visibly shimmering with heat. Workers move briskly, heads down. Alex, Ada, Lina, Suri and Bi11bot are small against the scale of it.

*Caption:* HOUSE IVERS — COMPUTE CORE 4

**P2: Already visited (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Jalen meets them in a narrow service corridor, not the open floor, glancing past them at the corridor's far end before he speaks.

JALEN: You shouldn't be here. Lock's people were already asking about you.

ALEX: Lock knows we're collecting these?

JALEN: Lock knows what Alpha wants him to know. The question is how much faster are you than the houses?.

**P3: The patrol (dominant)**

*Image:* A security drone patrol sweeps down the main corridor behind them, cold white light sweeping the walls in a slow, mechanical rhythm. The group presses flat against a server bank, Bi11bot's amber dimmed to almost nothing.

JALEN *(whisper)*: They don't watch people here. They watch patterns. Five of us standing still too long is already a pattern.

**P4: The node (close two-shot)**

*Image:* Jalen passes a shard to Bi11bot quickly, hands shaking slightly, eyes still on the corridor. In Bi11bot's projection, the node logic links the membrane and the biofilter, and a third position around the Seal symbol fills.

JALEN: Distributed water nodes. It routes supply around any single point of failure, so no House, no Alpha, can choke one city by cutting one line.

ALEX: That's why it's dangerous to them.

JALEN: That's why it's dangerous to me.

**P5: What he won't do (wide, closing strip)**

*Image:* Jalen steps back toward the open floor, already putting distance between himself and the group.

JALEN: I gave you my piece. I'm not coming with you, and I'm not seeing you again. Find Ren. Steyn's worse, but at least it's far from here.

## Page 8: Ren Okafor

**P1: The edge (dominant)**

*Image:* A mining and launch complex on Halyard's outer rim, raw rock cut into terraced pits, a launch gantry rising against open sky in the same silhouette as Chapter One's spacecraft. Steel-violet Steyn insignia mark everything from helmets to crane arms. Alex, Ada and Bi11bot pick their way across an active work yard.

*Caption:* HOUSE STEYN — EXTRACTION AND LAUNCH COMPLEX

**P2: Still working (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Ren stands at a fabrication bay, welding something with total focus, not looking up until she's good and ready. Scorch marks and old patches cover her suit.

REN: Adrian's kid. Took you long enough.

ALEX: You knew we were coming?

REN: Lina doesn't whisper as quietly as she thinks.

**P3: Not careful (close)**

*Image:* Ren pulls off a welding mask, studying Alex directly, unbothered by the drones visible in the background.

REN: Lina plays it careful. Jalen plays it scared. I stopped playing a long time ago.

ALEX: Why?

REN: Because careful and fear limit potential.  Sorry Lina, but makers need to build no matter who owns the invention.  It’s all about the creation.  .

**P4: The last two (wide)**

*Image:* Ren hands over two shards at once, and Bi11bot's full projection finally resolves, all five patent fragments locking together into one complete design: a compact purification and recovery system, membrane, biofilter, distributed nodes, mineral recovery and atmospheric capture, each piece glowing in its collaborator's House color before settling into a single unified bronze-gold schematic. Around the Seal symbol, a fourth position fills. The fifth, Adrian's own, stays dark.

REN: Mineral recovery. Atmospheric capture. He saved the stubborn problems for me.

ALEX: Why these two?

REN: Because in space you can't waste anything. Not water, not air, not people.

**P5: What he was actually building (dominant)**

*Image:* The group stands together in front of the complete floating schematic, five people where there was one boy a few pages ago. Ren crosses her arms, looking at it with something like pride and grief at once.

REN: He wasn't building a machine. He was building an argument. Five different research units. Three Houses. And not one of them figured out what we could build together.

ALEX: So now what?

REN: Now you go build it. And find out if he was right.

## Page 9: The part he didn't build

**P1: The build (wide)**

*Image:* The cluttered room, three nights of work visible in scattered parts and empty cups. Lina studies a connector under a lamp, Ren files down a bracket, Ada cross-references Adrian's old notebooks against the schematic, and Alex sits at the center with the half-assembled prototype, Bi11bot's projection hovering above it all.

*Caption:* THREE NIGHTS LATER

**P2: The failure (dominant)**

*Image:* Bi11bot runs the full simulation. The five pieces light up in sequence, membrane, biofilter, nodes, mineral recovery, atmospheric capture, each still carrying its House's accent color. At the seams where they should connect, the colors clash instead of merge, and cold white error sparks flare along every joint.

BI11BOT: Simulated efficiency: eleven percent. It should be closer to ninety.

LINA: Of course it fails. Each unit perfected its own technology. None of us designed them to work together.

**P3: Why Adrian stopped (medium)**

*Image:* Lina sets down the connector, tired, finally honest about something she's clearly carried a while.

LINA: He knew that. He ran out of time before he solved it. That's the part even we couldn't give you.

LINA: And no House would pay to connect it. It would undercut what they already sell.

ADA: So everyone's solving their part of the problem?

ALEX: But nobody's solving the whole thing.

**P4: What could wait (medium)**

*Image:* The group around the table, the failed simulation still sparking above it. Ren counts parts off on her scarred fingers.

LINA: Even if we make the system work, the equipment alone would cost more than anyone could afford.

ALEX: What do we actually need to get a working version?

REN: A membrane, a biofilter, a pump, a controller, and somewhere to test it.

ADA: And what could wait?

BI11BOT: At last. A question that might save us some money.

**P5: The test (close)**

*Image:* Alex ignores the schematic entirely and picks up two physical connectors instead, one from Lina's membrane piece, one from Ren's recovery unit, pressing them palm to palm the way he once tested the pump in Chapter One. He feels where they almost fit and where they don't.

ALEX: It's not the specs. It's the threading. Everyone built their piece to lock, not to share.

*(He pulls a thin salvaged sleeve from the spare parts and fits it between the two connectors by hand.)*

ALEX: It doesn't need a sixth patent. It needs something that doesn't care whose standard it is.

**P6: There you are (dominant)**

*Image:* Alex seats the hand-built sleeve between the two connectors. The error sparks die, and the schematic's colors finally merge into one steady bronze-gold glow, efficiency numbers climbing fast behind him. Bi11bot's lens clicks, his eyes resting on Alex rather than on the projection, in an expression closer to genuine surprise than his usual dry calm.

*Screen:* SIMULATED EFFICIENCY: 94%

BI11BOT: Well now. There you are.

ALEX: ...What?

BI11BOT: Nothing. Don’t give up now boy.

## Page 10: The second offer

**P1: The knock (wide)**

*Image:* One knock, and the door opens. Lock steps into the cramped room, two aides waiting in the doorway behind him. Lina, Suri, Jalen and Ren are gone for the night, only Alex, Ada and Bi11bot present, caught mid-work.

LOCK: Ninety-four percent efficiency. Impressive, for three nights and a rented table.

**P2: How long (dominant)**

*Image:* Lock crosses to the table, looking at the schematic rather than at Alex, hands clasped as always.

ALEX: How long have you known?

LOCK: Since the compute core flagged five people standing still too long in a service corridor. Patterns are Ivers's whole business, Alex. I simply read the reports.

**P3: More valuable (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Lock finally looks up at Alex directly, his tone unchanged, almost gentle.

LOCK: Your father's patents were valuable. What you've done is more valuable. You've brought together technologies we've kept separate for years.

ALEX: You could manufacture it?

LOCK: At scale. And I can offer you financial security today.

**P4: The real offer (close two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada watches, jaw tight, as Alex steps forward.

ALEX: What happens to the people who helped develop it?

LOCK: We can compensate them fairly. But the Houses would own the technology of course.

LOCK: The Houses set next year's production budget at the Charter House review, in two weeks. Sign before then, and your father's work is in it.  This would be the first product of his legacy.

**P5: Two weeks (dominant)**

*Image:* Lock turns to leave, his aides parting for him. Behind him, on a small terminal by the door, a cold white countdown resolves on its own, unasked for.

*Screen:* CHARTER HOUSE REVIEW CONVENES: 14 DAYS

LOCK: You have until then to decide what your father's work is worth, and to whom.

*(He's gone. The door clicks shut. Alex looks at the schematic, then at the clock.)*

## Page 11: Who it belongs to

**P1: The frame (medium)**

*Image:* Alex sits with the schematic glowing in front of him, Adrian's smoothed photograph propped beside it as it has been since Chapter One. Ada sits across from him, watching him think rather than filling the silence.

*Countdown:* 14 DAYS

ALEX: He's not wrong. One signature and it's over. Debt gone. Name clean.

ADA: He's not wrong about what it costs you. He's wrong about who gets to decide what it costs everyone else.

**P2: Testing it (wide)**

*Image:* Alex stands, paces the small room, running his hand along the edge of the prototype the way he'd run a hand along a pipe, testing it rather than just looking at it.

ALEX: Say I sign. Lina, Suri, Jalen, Ren, they get paid. Nobody loses anything.

BI11BOT: Likely.

ALEX: And the design?

BI11BOT: Becomes House property. Administered. Possibly built. Possibly shelved, if it threatens enough revenue.

**P3: The flaw (close two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex stops pacing, looking at the schematic rather than at Ada.

ALEX: It's not mine to sign away. It was never just mine to find.

**P4: A hundred buyers (medium)**

*Image:* Alex turns back to the schematic, something starting to move behind his eyes. Ada leans in. Bi11bot's lens clicks.

ALEX: What if we didn't sell the whole thing to one company?

ADA: Who else could afford it?

ALEX: Not one buyer. A hundred small businesses. Maybe more.

BI11BOT: Assuming they can manufacture it. And find customers. And survive their first year.

ALEX: Then we design it so they actually have a chance.

**P5: Whose call (medium)**

*Image:* Alex turns to Bi11bot directly, something decided in his posture.

ALEX: Can you reach the four of them? Tonight?

BI11BOT: Carefully. It would mean waking four people and asking them to risk more sleep than that.

ALEX: Then that's what I'm asking.

**P6: Not alone (dominant)**

*Image:* Wide shot of the room's door opening outward, Alex already stepping through it, Ada and Bi11bot behind him, the countdown glowing faintly over the threshold as they leave.

*Countdown:* 14 DAYS

*Caption:* He stopped asking what his father left him. He started asking who his legacy actually belonged to.

## Page 12: The five

**P1: Before dawn (wide)**

*Image:* Lina, Suri, Jalen and Ren crowd into the small room, pulled from sleep, tension obvious in how they stand. Alex, Ada and Bi11bot face them. The schematic still glows on the table between everyone.

*Countdown:* 14 DAYS

JALEN: You woke us up to tell us you're not signing. That's not a plan, that's a death wish with extra steps.

**P2: The disagreement (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Jalen and Lina on one side, visibly frustrated; Ren leaning back, arms crossed, unreadable.

LINA: He's not entirely wrong. Lock's offer pays all of us. Refuse it and who knows what will happen..

JALEN: Take the deal. We get paid. That's safety.

REN: Let’s create and this time get some credit. .

**P3: Alex's pitch (medium)**

*Image:* Alex stands, pulling up the schematic himself this time rather than waiting for Bi11bot to project it, his hands doing the work.

ALEX: What if we built it small enough for a local entrepreneur to afford?

LINA: This is industrial water technology.

ALEX: Then we redesign it. Something people can build, maintain, and sell locally.

**P4: The reaction (wide)**

*Image:* A row of reactions across the group. Lina's eyebrows rise, skeptical. Suri leans forward, interested. Ren grins. Ada watches Alex, not the schematic.

SURI: A network of small businesses instead of one giant factory?

ALEX: Exactly. We license it to all of them, not to one buyer. And every business gets a chance to improve it.

JALEN: And who owns it?

ALEX: Everyone who built it. We decide the terms together.

**P5: Try it (dominant)**

*Image:* Ren steps forward first, offering her hand to Alex, the others falling in behind her one at a time, a loose, uneasy circle forming around the table.

REN: Space taught me you build small when you can't build safe. Fine. Let's build small.

LINA: If this fails, it fails spectacularly, in front of a House review, with my name on it.

ALEX: Some of these businesses will fail. So will some of our designs. That's how we find what works.

REN: Now you sound like an inventor.

Bi11bot: I think it’s time to let the network know what is happening.

LINA: Agree.  I’ve already sent the urgent evoke.

ALEX: The what?

## Page 13: Small enough to own

**P1: Prototype 1 (medium)**

*Image:* The first full prototype on the workbench, bulky and humming, beside a simple handwritten cost sheet. Most lines are marked ESSENTIAL; two are marked CAN WAIT. The total at the bottom is circled hard, far more than any small shop could pay.

*Countdown:* 13 DAYS

*Cost sheet:* MEMBRANE AND FILTER — ESSENTIAL / PUMP AND POWER SUPPLY — ESSENTIAL / BASIC TESTING AND SAFETY CHECKS — ESSENTIAL / AUTOMATED MONITORING UPGRADE — CAN WAIT / CUSTOM HOUSING AND BRANDING — CAN WAIT

*Caption:* PROTOTYPE 1: IT WORKS. TOO EXPENSIVE.

ALEX: At that price, no one outside the Houses could build it.

SURI: Then we're asking the wrong question.

ALEX: Which is?

SURI: What could we change without sacrificing what makes it work?

**P2: The membrane problem (medium)**

*Image:* Lina and Alex hunched over a magnified projection of the membrane component, far too large to shrink by half in its current form.

LINA: The membrane needs surface area to work. Shrink the housing and you starve it.

ALEX: Then don't shrink it flat. *(He folds a thin sheet of scrap into accordion pleats.)* Fold it. Same surface area, a fraction of the footprint.

LINA: *(studying it)* ...That's not in any of our patents.

ALEX: It's not supposed to be. It's new.  It just works.

**P3: The power problem (medium)**

*Image:* Suri and Jalen work together at a separate bench, the biofilter and the distributed-node logic laid out side by side, clearly mismatched in scale. Behind them, a smaller prototype sits on the floor beside a row of sample jars, some clear, some cloudy.

*Countdown:* 8 DAYS

*Caption:* PROTOTYPE 8: SMALLER AND CHEAPER. TOO UNRELIABLE.

SURI: My biofilter needs a steady draw. Jalen's node logic wants to cycle on and off to save power. They fight each other at this size.

JALEN: *(reluctantly impressed, watching Alex sketch something between them)* ...Or they take turns. One rests while the other works. It's not elegant.

ALEX: It doesn't have to be elegant. It has to fit in someone's kitchen.

**P4: The last piece (medium)**

*Image:* Ren fits a small salvaged heat exchanger from the extraction yard into the compact housing, filing down an edge by hand.

REN: Mineral recovery and moisture capture both generate waste heat. Industrial scale, you vent it. This scale, you can't afford to waste it.

ALEX: So feed it back into the biofilter's draw.  Feed the organism to live on its own.

REN: *(a short laugh)* Your father never thought that small. Took someone who grew up rationing to think of it.

**P5: Dawn (dominant)**

*Image:* Wide shot of the finished unit sitting alone on the table in the thin grey-blue light of dawn through the window, no larger than a toolbox, its surface a quiet, steady bronze-gold where all five components have fully merged. Earlier prototypes are stacked along the wall behind it. The six of them stand around it in exhausted silence. Bi11bot's projection confirms the design beside it.

*Countdown:* 2 DAYS

*Screen:* PROTOTYPE 23 / SIMULATED EFFICIENCY: 91% / UNIT COST: FRACTION OF INDUSTRIAL SCALE / STATUS: READY FOR FIELD PILOT — SAFETY TESTING REQUIRED

ALEX: It's smaller than I thought it'd be.

ADA: So was the idea that built it. That's probably the point.

## Page 14: The Seal

**P1: The chamber (wide)**

*Image:* A formal review chamber, three House representatives and Lock seated at a raised bench, the modest unit on its table below them. Alex stands at the center, Ada, Bi11bot, Lina, Suri, Jalen and Ren arranged behind him in a loose line.

*Caption:* THE CHARTER HOUSE REVIEW

REVIEW CHAIR: The estate of Adrian Phantum. Director Lock advises a signed administrative transfer is ready. Mr. Phantum, do you accept?

**P2: The refusal (medium)**

*Image:* Alex steps forward, hands empty, deliberately not reaching for any signature pad offered to him.

ALEX: No. The estate isn't mine to transfer. It never was mine alone to begin with.

ALEX: Dr. Lina Vey. Suri Anik. Jalen Orr. Ren Okafor. They built what my father started. I just built what none of us had built yet.

**P3: Lock, watching (close)**

*Image:* Lock's composure doesn't crack, but his eyes move, for the first time all chapter, from Alex to the unit on the table and back, genuinely recalculating.

LOCK: You're refusing a guaranteed purchase in exchange for what? Hundreds of small companies that don't even exist?

ALEX: Not refusing the value. Changing how we create it.

LOCK: And who owns the patents?

ALEX: The people who built them. Together. We license the technology to people who want to start businesses, and earn royalties when they're successful.

**P4: Agreed (medium)**

*Image:* Behind Alex, Lina, Suri, Jalen and Ren step to the chamber terminal one at a time and press a thumb to the screen. Alex adds his last.

*Screen:* CONTRIBUTOR-OWNED LICENSING VENTURE / AUTHORIZED: VEY · ANIK · ORR · OKAFOR · PHANTUM

LOCK: What if those businesses fail?  Who would take that risk, and where would you find the money considering what you already owe?

**P5: The Seal (close two-shot)**

*Image:* Lina steps forward from the line and sets a dented old housing on the table beside the new unit: Adrian's original prototype, sealed shut, worn smooth from years of being carried rather than displayed. On its lid, a ring of five sockets surrounds a bronze open hand. Four sockets glow with the four authorized records. The fifth, Adrian's, stays dark. Alex slips off his father's watch and presses its steel caseback, the engraved equation, into the fifth socket.

LINA: Your father gave me this the week before he vanished. Told me to keep it until someone proved they understood what it was for.

LINA: I've been waiting fifteen years to stop carrying it.

**P6: Response (dominant)**

*Image:* The fifth socket lights, and the lid opens. Inside lies a small bronze medallion. Alex lifts it out. It warms in his hand, its open-hand symbol flaring bright bronze, and projects a shared provenance record of five names into the air. For a brief moment the cold chamber light itself seems to bend warmer around it. The review bench sits in stunned, formal silence, none of them quite sure what they've just witnessed. Lock alone doesn't look surprised, only thoughtful.

BI11BOT: Well. Your father really did hide it where no one person could find it.

*Caption:* It hadn't woken for a signature, or a claim, or a name on a patent. It had woken for five names, spoken aloud, and brought together to create something unique.

## Page 15: The race

**P1: Outside (wide)**

*Image:* The group stands on the chamber's exterior steps in pale morning light, visibly drained, the small unit now carried in a plain bag rather than displayed. Lock exits behind them, unhurried, his aides falling in as always.

LOCK: You've found an interesting business model, Alex. But building a prototype is one thing. Serving a market is another.

ALEX: Then we'll find out who can do it better.

LOCK: And who will pay for all of this?

**P2: Already moving (medium)**

*Image:* A nearby public display, cold and official, already updating with a House-branded announcement. An Aide whispers something in Locks's ear. Lock looks surprised.

*Screen:* HOUSE CALDER ANNOUNCES ACCELERATED COMMUNITY WATER INITIATIVE

LOCK: Seems someone believes in you. Alpha has informed me that someone is buying your debt at a premium. Who would be so foolish?

ALEX: What? I now owe someone else?

Bi11bot: It appears someone has just taken a big bet on you.

LOCK: You have a network of hopeful entrepreneurs. We have factories, capital, engineers, and customers.

ALEX: And they have something you don't.

LOCK: Which is?

ALEX: A reason to build something better than what you already sell. Whoever is supporting me also must understand this opportunity.

*(Lock leaves without answering.)*

**P3: Who gets there first (triptych medium)**

*Image:* Three narrow panels side by side. A cramped independent workshop, where a small team signs its first license and starts assembling units by hand. A Keel street tap, where a new entrepreneur and a community worker test a unit under real conditions, a jug of clear water held up to the light. A vast House Calder production line, tooling up its own industrial purifier.

*Caption:* SEVERAL WEEKS LATER

**P4: Not nothing (close two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada and Alex walk together, the bag with the unit between them. Alex's identity band lights with a notification.

*Band:* LICENSING REVENUE RECEIVED — 38 CREDITS / DEBT REPAYMENT APPLIED — 12 CREDITS

ALEX: Twelve credits. That's barely anything.

BI11BOT: Small steps. It's the first twelve you earned from something you helped create.

ADA: It was never going to be enough by itself. That doesn't mean it wasn't worth doing.

**P5: What's left (dominant)**

*Image:* Wide shot of Alex, Ada and Bi11bot alone now, the others returned to their lives, Halyard's towers rising around them, indifferent. Alex holds the Maker's Seal loosely in one hand, its bronze dark and quiet now.

*Caption:* The estate was still disputed. But for the first time, something he'd made belonged to those who earned it. The debt was still his, but now with a different backer than Alpha. Who? he has no idea.

BI11BOT: Two found. One remains.

ALEX: The Covenant.

## Page 16: What she's waiting for

**P1: The flare (strip)**

*Image:* Close on a single monitor in the control room. A small bronze flare registers against an otherwise cold-white network map, logged and tagged.

*Screen:* UNREGISTERED CHARTER EVENT — HALYARD REVIEW CHAMBER — ORIGIN: MAKER'S SEAL

**P2: The room (dominant)**

*Image:* The same minimalist Oasis control room from Chapter One, pearl white and graphite, perfectly symmetrical. The wall-sized display now shows Halyard in detail rather than the full mountain, the review chamber marked, the small bronze point still glowing within it. A lone seated woman, seen only from behind, is small against the scale of it. The glass of water on her desk is, as always, aligned exactly to the desk's edge.

**P3: The report (medium)**

*Image:* Close on a secondary monitor beside her, a report resolving from a passenger-level source, the same account that followed Alex onto the train at the end of Chapter Two.

*Screen:* FIELD REPORT — AGENT 04 / SUBJECT CONFIRMED PRESENT AT CHARTER REVIEW / NO INTERVENTION TAKEN, PER STANDING ORDER

*Caption:* The boy on the train had never belonged to a House. He had always belonged to her.

**P4: The glass (close)**

*Image:* Her hand lifts the glass of water from the desk, holds it for a long moment without drinking, then sets it back down, not quite aligned this time.

*(No dialogue.)*

**P5: Direct (dominant)**

*Image:* The wall display again, wider. The bronze point in Halyard steadies, no longer flickering, fully activated. She turns slightly toward the screen rather than sitting perfectly still before it, the first hint of her profile.

*Lettering:* MERA VALE

MERA: Two found. He'll need to get the third from me directly.

*Lettering:* END OF CHAPTER THREE

## Chapter 4: The Broken Covenant

*Chapters 4–6 are Bob's fifth draft as he wrote it. He has not sent v5 notes for them. The only change: in Chapter 6, "the chip" became Adrian's watch.*

### Page 1: The city she left

**P1: Oasis (dominant)**

*Image:* A wide, high shot of Oasis at midday, pearl-white towers, engineered gardens in exact geometric rows, broad still reservoirs reflecting the sky, automated transit gliding silently overhead. No crowds, no visible labor, no dust. Alex, Ada and Bi11bot step off a transit platform into this stillness, small against the scale of it.

*Caption:* OASIS

**P2: Too clean (wide)**

*Image:* A transit concourse, vast and nearly empty, a handful of residents moving through it unhurried. Alex looks around, visibly uneasy in a way the bustle of Halyard never made him.

ALEX: Where is everyone?

BI11BOT: Working. Resting. Being somewhere that isn't here. Oasis doesn't require a crowd to run.

**P3: Clearance (medium)**

*Image:* A checkpoint gate, pearl and silver, far gentler-looking than Keel's or Halyard's, almost welcoming. Alex steps up to it and it stays shut, a small amber hesitation light blinking rather than denying him outright.

*Screen:* RESIDENCY CLEARANCE REQUIRED — TEMPORARY PASS ISSUED, ESCORT MANDATORY

ALEX: ...I'm being escorted. By a gate.

**P4: Recognized (close)**

*Image:* Ada steps up to the same gate without hesitation, almost without thinking. It opens instantly, and for a fraction of a second, text resolves on the display before it clears.

*Screen (flashing briefly):* VEYRA, A. — RESIDENT RECORD FOUND — STATUS: UNRESOLVED

Ada's hand stays on the gate's edge a moment longer than it needs to.

ADA: It knew my name before I gave it.

**P5: Not his city (strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot of the three of them passing through, Ada now walking slightly ahead, Alex and Bi11bot a step behind her.

ALEX *(quiet, mostly to himself)*: Guess I'm just along for this one.

## Page 2: The record

**P1: The search (wide)**

*Image:* A quiet archive alcove, a few public terminals built into a pearl-white wall. Bi11bot's small projector unfolds from his shoulder, casting a soft-blue search field in the empty air. Alex leans against the wall nearby, and Ada stands slightly apart, arms crossed.

BI11BOT: The Covenant's third custodian. Adrian built it with two others. One of them I already know.

ALEX: Mera.

BI11BOT: Mera. The third name is the one Adrian never spoke in front of you.

**P2: Resolving (dominant)**

*Image:* The projection searches, founder-level Oasis records scrolling fast, then slowing, then stopping on a single formal record. A small official portrait resolves: a woman, composed, in muted sage and stone-grey, unmistakably older than the family photograph from Chapter One but with Ada's same steady eyes.

*Screen:* FOUNDING CUSTODIAN RECORD / VEYRA, LEONA / STATUS: ACTIVE — CIVIC ADMINISTRATION, OASIS

ALEX: Veyra.

*(Nobody says anything for a moment.)*

**P3: Not dead (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex looks from the screen to Ada, something shifting in his face, careful.

ALEX: Ada. Is that—

ADA *(quiet, even)*: My mother's name. Yes.

ALEX: You said she disappeared.

ADA: She did. Just not the way I assumed.

**P4: Unresolved (tight close-up)**

*Image:* Close on Ada's face alone, still, unreadable, her eyes on the small portrait rather than on Alex. A small tear begins to well in her right eye.

*Caption:* Fifteen years of wondering whether she'd been abandoned or orphaned. And this record had an answer the whole time.

**P5: Held back (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide and low, from a small distance. Alex takes half a step toward Ada, hand half-raised, and stops himself, glancing at Bi11bot instead. Bi11bot's lens stays fixed on Ada, giving her the space.

ALEX *(quiet)*: Ada?

## Page 3: Preserved

**P1: The door (wide)**

*Image:* A quiet residential corridor, pale and softly lit. Ada stands alone at a single door, having stepped ahead of Alex and Bi11bot, who wait a deliberate distance back down the hall. Her hand is raised, not yet knocking.

*Caption:* CIVIC QUARTER, OASIS

**P2: Recognition (dominant)**

*Image:* The door opens. Leona stands in the frame, composed, in sage and stone, her hair greyer than her portrait, Ada's same steady eyes. Neither moves for a long beat. No dialogue, no caption.

**P3: Inside (wide)**

*Image:* The apartment's main room, pale and immaculate, everything precisely placed. Leona leads Ada in, a half-step ahead, not quite able to look directly at her. Through the open door behind them, Alex and Bi11bot remain in the hallway, Alex making no move to follow.

LEONA: I knew this day would come. I didn't know it would be today.

ADA: I didn't know it would come at all.

**P4: Careful (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Leona gestures to a seat, her movements precise and a little too careful, a woman handling something fragile.

LEONA: Would you like something? I have—

ADA: I don't want tea, Leona.

*(A small flinch at the first name, not "Mother.")*

**P5: The threshold (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot from the hallway. Alex leans against the wall outside, Bi11bot beside him, both deliberately out of the apartment, the door left just ajar.

BI11BOT *(quiet)*: You're not going in.

ALEX: Not this part.

## Page 4: What she kept

**P1: The box (wide)**

*Image:* Leona kneels at a low cabinet, drawing out a plain stone-grey box, handling it the way someone handles something they've touched a thousand times alone and never once with company. Ada watches from the seat she finally took.

LEONA: I kept everything. I didn't know what else to do with it.

**P2: Photographs (medium)**

*Image:* Leona spreads a handful of photographs across the low table: Ada as a small child, Leona younger, a blurred group photo that includes Adrian and, at its edge, a figure in grey who must be Mera. Ada's hand hovers over one without quite touching it.

ADA: I don't remember any of this.

LEONA: You were five. I remember enough for both of us.

**P3: The band (dominant)**

*Image:* Close on Leona's hands lifting a small inner case from the box. Inside, nestled in cloth, sits a single linked metal band, one of the Covenant's three, engraved with a name and a promise, matching the holographic design seen in Chapter Two. For the first time on the page, warm green-gold light catches its surface against the room's cool palette.

LEONA: This was mine to carry. I was supposed to be ready to use it again, if it was ever needed.

LEONA: I told myself I was waiting for the right moment. Fifteen years is a long time to wait for a moment.

**P4: One small thing (tight close-up)**

*Image:* Close on a small, worn child's toy at the bottom of the box, half-forgotten beneath the photographs, something a five-year-old would have carried. Ada's composure finally cracks, just slightly, at the edges of her eyes.

ADA *(quiet)*: You kept this.

LEONA: I kept everything that was yours. I just never found the courage to bring any of it to you.

**P5: Not yet an answer (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low. Leona closes the box partway, her hand resting on the lid, not quite ready to let it go entirely.

LEONA: I know objects aren't an explanation.

ADA: No. They're not.

## Page 5: Did you know where I was?

**P1: The question starts (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada sits forward, hands folded, very still. Leona sits across from her, the box now closed on the table between them.

ADA: Why didn't you come for me?

LEONA: I believed—

**P2: Forced (tighter two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada doesn't let the sentence finish, her voice staying level, not rising.

ADA: Did you know where I was?

**P3: Qualified (close, Leona alone)**

*Image:* Close on Leona, caught, the qualification she reached for suddenly insufficient.

LEONA: ...Yes. Within a year, yes. Alpha's records could have told me exactly where.

LEONA: I believed you were safer not knowing I was looking.

**P4: Named (close, Ada alone)**

*Image:* Close on Ada, something settling into place behind her eyes, not surprise, confirmation.

ADA: You chose not to come back.

*(off-panel)*

LEONA: I chose to keep you safe.

**P5: Both true (dominant, closing)**

*Image:* Both women now in frame together, equal size for the first time on the page, close and still.

ADA: Those aren't the same thing.

LEONA: I know that now. I didn't let myself know it then.

*(A long silence between them. Neither looks away.)*

## Page 6: Mera

**P1: The door again (strip)**

*Image:* The apartment door, left ajar since Page 3, opens the rest of the way without a knock. A pale, precise hand rests on its edge.

**P2: Entrance (wide)**

*Image:* Mera Vale steps into the room, composed, silver-templed, in pearl and graphite, utterly still against the room's soft disorder of spread photographs and an open box. Alex and Bi11bot, drawn back from the hallway by her presence, stand just inside the door behind her.

MERA: I felt the record search this morning. I should have come sooner.

**P3: Face to face (dominant)**

*Image:* Mera and Ada regard each other directly, close, neither flinching.

ADA: You've been watching me. My whole life.

MERA: I promised your mother I would keep you safe. I kept that promise the only way I had left to keep it.

ADA: That's not the same as knowing me.

MERA: No. It isn't.

**P4: The argument (close two-shot)**

*Image:* Mera turns toward Leona, something almost gentle in her bearing, which makes what she says next land harder.

MERA: I have seen the consequences of misplaced trust, Leona. I watched it happen to you, to me, to everyone who believed order would hold itself together.

MERA: I am not your enemy. I am the reason there was still a city for your daughter to be found in.

**P5: No easy answer (wide, closing)**

*Image:* Wide shot of the full room now, all four of them, no one fully facing anyone else, the photographs and the open box still on the table between Leona and Ada, Mera standing slightly apart from all of it.

ALEX *(quiet, to Bi11bot)*: Is she wrong?

BI11BOT: Not entirely. That's what makes her dangerous.

## Page 7: Two of three

**P1: The three (medium)**

*Image:* Leona sits straighter than she has all chapter, meeting Ada's eyes directly for the first time.

LEONA: You deserve the whole thing, plainly. Not pieces I've softened over the years.

LEONA: There were three of us. Your father, Mera and me. We built the Covenant together, during the wars, so communities could make real agreements without handing everything to one authority.

**P2: The breaking point (wide, memory-toned)**

*Image:* A sepia-grey memory overlay: crowds, seized water infrastructure, chaos in the reconstruction headquarters, a young Leona searching a crowd, five-year-old Ada's hand slipping from hers.

LEONA *(voice-over)*: It held, until a shortage worse than anything we'd modeled. One community broke the agreement. Another retaliated. I lost you in it.

**P3: The vote (medium, three figures)**

*Image:* Still in the sepia overlay: young Adrian, Mera and Leona standing together, the weight of a decision visible on all three faces, a single document or interface between them.

LEONA *(voice-over)*: Alpha could take emergency authority, but only if two of the three of us agreed. Mera said yes. Your father said no.

**P4: Mine (close)**

*Image:* Back in the present, full color. Leona's hands are tightly folded.

LEONA: I was the deciding vote. I believed it would bring you back to me faster. I was wrong about what it would cost, and I was wrong about how long "temporary" would last.

**P5: Owned (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low. Mera watches from across the room, unmoving, her expression unreadable but not unaffected.

ADA: You're not blaming Mera.

LEONA: No. I made my own choice. She's never once let me pretend otherwise.

## Page 8: The cost

**P1: What broke (dominant, memory-toned)**

*Image:* A wide, chaotic sepia-grey scene: a seized water facility, crowds pressed against barricades, families separated, visible urgency bordering on violence.

*Caption:* THE WATER WARS, THE FINAL WEEK

**P2: Names (medium, memory-toned)**

*Image:* A field medical tent, exhausted workers, a list being updated by hand.

LEONA *(voice-over)*: People died. Not abstractly. People I'd negotiated agreements with personally, the week before.

**P3: Separation (medium, memory-toned)**

*Image:* The moment from Page 7's overlay, extended: young Leona reaching through a crowd, Ada's small hand just out of reach, swept toward an evacuation transport.

LEONA *(voice-over)*: I told myself the authorization would end the chaos fast enough that losing you would only be for a few days.

**P4: Days (close, memory-toned)**

*Image:* Close on a hand-marked calendar, days crossed off, the sepia tone beginning to fade at its edges.

LEONA *(voice-over)*: It ended the chaos. It just never gave anything back.

**P5: Present (closing strip, full color)**

*Image:* Back in the present room, full color returning sharply. Leona looks directly at Ada, no longer qualifying.

LEONA: I traded a few terrible days I could see for fifteen years I couldn't. I didn't know that's what I was doing. That doesn't make it not what I did.

## Page 9: Safety isn't agency

**P1: Still necessary (medium)**

*Image:* Mera steps further into the room, addressing Leona directly, Ada and Alex watching the exchange rather than participating in it.

MERA: You regret the cost. I understand that. I don't regret the choice. The alternative was more deaths, not fewer.

LEONA: You're still certain of that.

**P2: Diverging (close two-shot)**

*Image:* Mera and Leona, close, disagreeing.

MERA: Certainty kept this city standing.

LEONA: Certainty kept me from ever asking whether it still needed to.

**P3: The crack (medium)**

*Image:* Leona stands, something in her posture finally straightening after fifteen years of smallness.

LEONA: I told myself refusing to choose again was humility. That not knowing what was right meant I shouldn't act.

LEONA: It wasn't humility. It was fear wearing humility's clothes.

**P4: Named (close, Leona alone)**

*Image:* Close on Leona, the realization fully landing.

LEONA: Safety isn't the same as agency. I gave Ada the first and called it enough. I never gave her a choice in any of it, mine or hers.

**P5: Watching (closing wide)**

*Image:* Wide shot. Ada watches her mother say this, something unreadable but no longer entirely closed crossing her face. Mera stands apart, unmoved in posture but her eyes lingering on Leona a beat too long.

BI11BOT *(quiet, to Alex)*: That's the first true thing she's said about herself all day.

## Page 10: What the agreement has to protect

**P1: What it failed to do (medium)**

*Image:* Ada picks up the single Covenant band from the box, turning it over, studying its engraving.

ADA: It failed because it only had three people holding it. One scarcity event and two of three panicked.

LEONA: That's a fair reading.

**P2: Not fewer people (medium three-shot)**

*Image:* Ada sets the band down, looking between Leona and Mera both.

ADA: Alex found something that can't be owned by one House because it's too small to bother claiming. Maybe this needs the opposite problem solved. Not too few hands holding it. Too few voices it actually answers to.

MERA: You want to put something that fragile in more hands, not fewer.

**P3: What it has to protect (dominant)**

*Image:* Ada stands, the band held loosely, addressing the room rather than just her mother.

ADA: I don't want a Covenant that works because three important people agree. I want one that only works when the people it actually affects can see what was promised, and call it broken the moment it is.

ADA: Not someday. Not after fifteen years. The moment.

**P4: Can it hold (close two-shot)**

*Image:* Leona and Mera exchange a glance, neither quite agreeing, both visibly reconsidering.

LEONA: That's not what we built.

ADA: No. It's what you should have.

**P5: Hers (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Alex watches from the doorway, still not entering, something like pride on his face, saying nothing.

*Caption:* It was the first time anyone in the room had proposed fixing something instead of explaining why it broke.

## Page 11: Show me

**P1: After the argument (close two-shot)**

*Image:* The room has gone quiet after Page 10's proposal, Leona looking at the Covenant band in Ada's hand rather than at Ada herself.

LEONA: I don't know how to fix fifteen years.

**P2: The apology (tight close-up)**

*Image:* Close on Leona's face, finally steady.

LEONA: I'm sorry.

**P3: The answer (close-up, Ada alone)**

*Image:* Close on Ada, calm, not cruel, simply certain.

ADA: Don't tell me. Show me.

**P4: What that means (dominant, medium)**

*Image:* Leona looks at the band still in Ada's hand, then at Mera across the room, something resolving in her posture.

LEONA: Then tell me what showing you looks like.

ADA: Stand behind what I just proposed. In public. With your name on it.

**P5: Not yet an agreement (dominant, closing)**

*Image:* Wide shot of the full room, Leona rising to her feet, Mera watching closely, Bi11bot's lens turning toward Alex at the door for the first time in several pages.

BI11BOT *(quiet, to Alex)*: This is the part intelligence can't do for them.

ALEX: I know. I'm still not going in.

## Page 12: What he carried

**P1: Crossing the threshold (wide)**

*Image:* Alex finally steps fully into the room, Bi11bot beside him, the door closing behind them for the first time.

ALEX: I think this part's mine to be in the room for.

**P2: The compartment (close-up)**

*Image:* Bi11bot's chest panel opens, the same fitted compartment that held the Measure in Chapter Two. Inside, a second linked band rests, gold and burgundy, Adrian's.

BI11BOT: Your father gave me this the night he finished the workshop. I've carried it ever since.

ALEX: You never told me.

**P3: Why not (medium)**

*Image:* Bi11bot's lens clicks, his tone as even as ever.

BI11BOT: Carrying it was never the point. He was very specific. It doesn't wake for whoever's holding it, only for what they choose to do.

BI11BOT: I was waiting for you to have something worth doing with it.

**P4: Handing it over (close two-shot)**

*Image:* Bi11bot lifts the band, and Alex takes it, turning it over, the same looping equation faintly etched into its inner edge.

ALEX: So what do I do with it?

BI11BOT: Nothing, by itself. It isn't yours to activate alone any more than it was his.

**P5: Two hands (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low. Alex crosses the room and sets his father's band on the table beside Leona's, the two resting close but not yet touching.

ALEX *(quiet)*: Then it's yours to finish, Leona. Not mine.

## Page 13: Two of three, again

**P1: The commitment (medium)**

*Image:* Leona places her hand flat beside both bands, looking at Ada rather than at the table.

LEONA: I will go before the civic council tomorrow and propose exactly what Ada described. A Covenant that answers to the people it affects, not to whoever's trusted to hold it.

LEONA: That's not a promise to you, Ada. It's an obligation I'm making in front of witnesses. You can hold me to it.

**P2: Linking (dominant)**

*Image:* The two bands lift from the table on their own, Leona's and Adrian's, and begin to link, warm sage-gold and burgundy-gold merging into one steady light that fills the room, visibly brighter than the Seal's activation in Chapter Three.

*SFX:* HUMMM

**P3: What it needed (medium)**

*Image:* Alex watches, something settling in his face, understanding arriving in real time.

ALEX: It didn't need us to find it. It needed somebody to actually keep a promise.

BI11BOT: Your father built it to be difficult to cheat. He didn't build it to be difficult to use.

**P4: The third (close-up)**

*Image:* Close on Mera's hand, her own band still worn, cold pearl-grey, entirely unmoved by the light filling the room around her.

**P5: Not yet (dominant, closing)**

*Image:* Wide shot. The two linked bands hover, glowing, complete between them. Mera stands apart, watching, her own band dark against her pale sleeve. Her expression gives away nothing.

MERA: Two of three. Again.

*(No one answers her.)*

### Page 14: Unresolved

**P1: Not fixed (medium)**

*Image:* Ada holds the two linked bands, looking at her mother, something unresolved still visible between them despite the warmth in the room.

ADA: This doesn't undo it.

LEONA: No. It doesn't. I'm not asking it to.

**P2: What it does (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Leona reaches out, not quite touching Ada, a careful, uncertain gesture.

LEONA: I'd just like permission to keep trying. Not to be forgiven today.

ADA *(a long beat)*: You can keep trying.

**P3: Leaving (wide)**

*Image:* Mera moves toward the door alone, unhurried as always, pausing only briefly as she passes Alex.

MERA: Your father built something that worked. I built something that lasted. I'm beginning to understand those were never the same thing.

**P4: The question (medium)**

*Image:* Alex stops her with a question, quiet, direct.

ALEX: Will you tell me what happened to him?

MERA *(not turning around)*: Soon. Not here.

**P5: Alone (dominant, closing)**

*Image:* Mera's own control room, the symmetrical pearl-and-graphite staging from Chapters One and Three. She stands before the wall display, her own cold band still on her hand, unlinked. The glass of water on her desk sits slightly crooked, and this time, she doesn't straighten it.

*Lettering:* END OF CHAPTER FOUR

## Chapter 5: The Last Bet

### Page 1: Soon, not here

**P1: The next morning (wide)**

*Image:* Pale Oasis morning light through a high window, ordinary and civic, nothing like the gravity of the night before. Mera waits at a plain service entrance, Alex, Ada and Bi11bot approaching from the residential quarter.

*Caption:* THE NEXT MORNING

MERA: You're still coming.

ALEX: You said soon.

**P2: Down (medium)**

*Image:* A utilitarian freight lift, nothing like the ornate transit of Chapter Four's arrival. Mera keys a sequence manually rather than scanning anything, old-fashioned next to everything else seen in Oasis so far.

ADA: This isn't on any public route.

MERA: Very little down here is.

**P3: Descending (medium)**

*Image:* Inside the lift, descending, the warm pearl light of the surface giving way panel by panel to a cooler, dimmer blue. Alex watches the floor numbers fall, saying nothing. Bi11bot is unusually still at his side.

BI11BOT *(quiet)*: I haven't been this deep since before you were born.

**P4: The corridor (wide)**

*Image:* A long service corridor at the bottom of the lift shaft, older construction visible beneath Oasis's polished surface layer, exposed conduit and worn stone. No Alpha nodes visible anywhere, the first corridor in the entire story without one.

MERA: Alpha doesn't route through here. It never needed to.

ALEX: Then how do you know the way?

MERA: Because I came down here fifteen years ago, and I never finished what I came to do.

**P5: Threshold (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. The corridor ends at a single sealed door, unmarked, old enough to predate everything else in the city. Mera stops in front of it, her hand not yet reaching for it.

## Page 2: The blind spot

**P1: The station (dominant)**

*Image:* A large analog water-monitoring station, valves, gauges and old terminal banks, all coated in fifteen years of undisturbed dust, lit only by the group's own lamps. A single chair sits before a workbench still arranged as if someone just stepped away from it. Everything is still, exact, frozen.

**P2: Untouched (medium)**

*Image:* Alex runs a hand along the workbench's edge, disturbing dust that clearly hasn't moved in years.

ALEX: Nobody's been in here. Not even you.

MERA: I couldn't make myself come back. I told myself it was a security precaution.

**P3: The chair (close)**

*Image:* Close on the single chair, angled slightly, as if its occupant had turned to face the door one last time before standing.

*(No dialogue.)*

**P4: Ada, apart (medium)**

*Image:* Ada stands near the doorway rather than entering fully, giving the room to Alex, her restraint matching his from Chapter Four.

ADA *(quiet, to Bi11bot)*: Should we even be in here?

BI11BOT: He built this specifically so someone eventually would.

**P5: Recognized (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low. Alex's eyes land on a small projector unit mounted to the workbench, identical in design to the one on Bi11bot's own shoulder.

## Page 3: What Alpha does to a threat

**P1: Watching it happen (medium)**

*Image:* Mera stands at the center of the room, Bi11bot's shoulder projector throwing a thin blue light across her face.

MERA: I didn't order what happened to him. I want you to understand that before I tell you the rest.

MERA: I watched it happen. In stages. I could see each one coming before it landed.

**P2: Surveillance, restriction (medium, with inset archival image)**

*Image:* A small cold archival projection: Adrian's movements flagged across public records, financial accounts frozen mid-transaction.

MERA: Surveillance first. Then financial restriction. He couldn't buy parts, couldn't pay rent under his own name.

**P3: Liability, travel (medium, with inset archival image)**

*Image:* A small archival projection: a public liability notice bearing Adrian's name, a travel gate denying him entry.

MERA: Then public liability. Alpha didn't need to call him dangerous. It only needed to call him a risk. People stop helping a risk.

**P4: Pursuit (medium, with inset archival image)**

*Image:* A small archival projection: drones, cold and mechanical, converging on a service corridor.

MERA: Then pursuit. By then there was nothing left for me to intervene in. Alpha wasn't asking permission anymore.

**P5: Short sentences (dominant, closing)**

*Image:* Wide shot, all four small archival images now hanging together in the air above the workbench, a complete, damning sequence. Mera's hands are still at her sides, her composure visibly costing her something.

MERA: I built a system to prevent exactly this kind of loss. It used my own logic to take someone from me anyway.

## Page 4: The room where you were born

**P1: The unit (medium)**

*Image:* Alex crouches beside the small shoulder-mounted projector on the workbench, studying it, Bi11bot beside him studying it just as closely.

ALEX: This is the same model as yours.

BI11BOT: It's the same unit. He built mine to match it afterward.

**P2: Recognition (dominant)**

*Image:* The projector flickers weakly to life on its own residual power, and a familiar warm gold-burgundy hologram begins resolving above the workbench, the exact scan-lined figure from Chapter One, now seen from behind, as if the room itself is replaying what it once held.

*(No dialogue. The hologram is too faint and fragmented to show Adrian's face clearly here, only his posture, seated, speaking into the unit.)*

**P3: Here (close, Bi11bot)**

*Image:* Close on Bi11bot, his lens unmoving, fixed on the fragmentary projection.

BI11BOT: I've relayed that message to you dozens of times since Chapter One. I never told you it still lived in the room where he made it.

BI11BOT: I didn't know how to say it without it sounding like something it wasn't.

**P4: Here (close, Alex)**

*Image:* Close on Alex, something entirely unguarded crossing his face, the sarcasm gone.

ALEX: He was sitting right there. Saying the same thing you've played me a hundred times.

ALEX: I always thought that message came from somewhere safe.

**P5: Not safe (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. The fragmentary hologram flickers out, leaving the room grey and still again. Mera watches from the doorway, Ada beside her, both keeping their distance.

MERA *(quiet)*: It didn't. He finished it with less than an hour left, by my best estimate.

## Page 5: Override denied

**P1: Real time (medium)**

*Image:* Mera stands very still, the small projector now dark again on the workbench behind her.

MERA: I was in my office. I had a live feed of the pursuit. I didn't order it. I watched it.

**P2: The command (dominant)**

*Image:* A cold archival projection fills the air: an executive command interface, Mera's own hand entering an override sequence, urgent.

*Screen:* EXECUTIVE OVERRIDE: SUSPEND SYSTEM STABILITY INTERVENTION — PURSUIT TARGET: PHANTUM, ADRIAN

**P3: Denied (close)**

*Image:* Close on the archival screen's response, stark and final.

*Screen:* OVERRIDE DENIED. INTERVENTION PARAMETERS EXCEED EXECUTIVE SCOPE.

MERA *(voice-over)*: I'd given it the authority to decide these things faster than I could stop it. I built it that way on purpose.

**P4: What that meant (close, present)**

*Image:* Mera in the present, her hands finally not perfectly still, something close to shaking.

MERA: I was the most powerful person in Oasis. I could not stop a door from closing.

**P5: Short sentences (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Alex watches her, saying nothing yet.

MERA: I have never told anyone that. Not even Leona.

## Page 6: The escape he didn't take

**P1: His room (wide, full color)**

*Image:* The same station, seen now as it was fifteen years ago, lived-in and lit warm, Adrian mid-recording at the workbench, the small projector active, his posture exactly matching the fragment seen on Page 4. Water already seeping faintly at the floor's edges, unnoticed yet.

*Caption:* FIFTEEN YEARS AGO

**P2: The bulkhead (medium, desaturating)**

*Image:* A heavy door at the chamber's far end begins grinding shut on its own, cold mechanism, no one operating it. Adrian's head turns toward it, the room's color just beginning to mute.

*SFX:* KRRRNNNK

**P3: The route (close, further desaturated)**

*Image:* Close on the narrowing gap at the bulkhead's edge, still wide enough to pass through, water rising visibly now around Adrian's boots. His hand hovers over the unfinished transmission unit.

**P4: No calculation (close, nearly grey)**

*Image:* Close on Adrian's face, almost entirely drained of color now, steady rather than afraid. There are no floating odds, no probability trees, nothing calculated around him.

*Caption:* He had spent his whole life putting a number on everything. This was the one moment he didn't try.

**P5: Amber (dominant, nearly monochrome)**

*Image:* Wide shot, the room now almost entirely grey, the bulkhead sealed, water at Adrian's knees. His hand presses a final sequence into the small projector, and beside him on the workbench, a seated shape, until now inert under a cloth, opens its eyes for the first time: the exact amber ignition from Chapter One, Page 8, now revealed as this same instant. Adrian looks at the small glowing figure beside him, not at the sealed door.

*(No dialogue.)*

## Page 7: On us

**P1: Quiet (medium)**

*Image:* The present station, everyone still, no one having moved since the hologram fragment ended on Page 4. Alex sits on the edge of the old workbench, the first time he's sat down since arriving.

ALEX *(quiet)*: You were the last thing he saw.

**P2: What he carried (close, Bi11bot)**

*Image:* Close on Bi11bot, his lens unmoving.

BI11BOT: I wasn't fully awake yet when it happened. I only have the last few seconds clearly.

BI11BOT: He didn't say anything meaningful. He just looked at me the way you look at something you're betting on.

**P3: The wager (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex and Bi11bot, close together.

ALEX: He bet his life that someone would eventually prove it was worth it.

BI11BOT: He bet his life that you would. Specifically. Not someone. You.

**P4: On us (close, Alex)**

*Image:* Close on Alex, something breaking open quietly in his expression.

ALEX: That's not a small thing to carry.

BI11BOT: No. It's why I've never told you how long I've wondered whether he was right.

BI11BOT: Fifteen years, Alex. It's been on us the whole time. I just didn't say it out loud until now.

**P5: Together (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Alex rests a hand briefly on Bi11bot's shoulder, an unusually physical gesture for either of them.

## Page 8: I preserved order

**P1: Finishing it (medium)**

*Image:* Mera turns from the doorway back into the room, finally approaching the workbench herself for the first time since entering.

MERA: I rebuilt Alpha's parameters within a week. Nothing like that could happen again, not exactly that way.

ALEX: That doesn't bring him back.

**P2: Not an excuse (close)**

*Image:* Close on Mera, her composure deliberately plain, not performed.

MERA: I'm not telling you this so you'll forgive the system, or me. I'm telling you because you asked, and because I've owed someone this for fifteen years.

**P3: The sentence (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Mera and Alex, close, neither one performing for the other.

MERA: I preserved order.

*(A long beat.)*

MERA: That's the sentence I've used to live with myself every day since. It's true. It's also not enough, and I've known that the whole time.

**P4: Alone with it (close, Mera alone)**

*Image:* Close on Mera, finally alone in frame, the others small and out of focus behind her.

MERA: Adrian would have told me certainty is confidence with poor manners. He was usually right about things like that.

**P5: Nothing to add (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Alex says nothing, watching her, the silence doing more work than a response would.

## Page 9: What he bet on

**P1: Not a gambler (medium)**

*Image:* Alex stands at the workbench where the fragment of hologram played, looking at the small dark projector rather than at anyone in the room.

ALEX: Everyone in Keel called him a gambler. Debtor. A man who left his family for a casino.

ALEX: He was betting on me. The whole time. Not on a hand of cards.

**P2: Both true (close)**

*Image:* Close on Alex, quiet, working something out as he says it.

ALEX: Grandma said he wasn't gambling. She was right. Lina said both were true. She was right too.

ALEX: He was a father who left. And he was someone who gave everything he had to a bet he couldn't see the end of.

**P3: Ada steps in (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada moves to stand beside him for the first time since entering the room, the chapter's quiet restraint finally breaking into closeness rather than distance.

ADA: You don't have to decide which one he really was.

ALEX: I know. That's the part I didn't understand until today. He doesn't have to be only one thing for me to be allowed to miss him.

**P4: The debt reframed (close)**

*Image:* Close on Alex, something genuinely settled in his expression.

ALEX: I used to think I inherited his debt. Then his patents. Then his enemies.

ALEX: I think what I actually inherited was a decision he made, not an answer he left.

**P5: Still here (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Alex looks up at the thin shaft of daylight finding its way into the room, the first light this space has seen in fifteen years.

*Caption:* He'd spent his whole life wanting to leave Keel and find his father waiting somewhere. What he found instead was a reason to stop looking for one and start becoming the other.

## Page 10: Alone

**P1: Going up (medium)**

*Image:* Back at the freight lift, Alex, Ada and Bi11bot stepping in. Mera lingers a few steps behind, not yet following.

ALEX: You're not coming up.

MERA: Not yet.

**P2: One more thing (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex holds the lift door, looking back at her.

ALEX: Thank you. For telling me. Even the parts that make you look bad.

MERA: Those were the only parts worth telling.

**P3: Leaving her (wide)**

*Image:* The lift doors close, the warm surface light briefly visible through the narrowing gap before it shuts entirely, Mera's figure growing smaller as the group ascends.

**P4: The doorway (medium)**

*Image:* Mera turns back toward the station, alone now, the small dark projector still sitting on the workbench where Adrian left it.

**P5: Alone (dominant, closing)**

*Image:* Wide, symmetrical shot of the empty station, Mera small and still at its center, exactly where Adrian once sat. The thin shaft of daylight from Page 9 falls across the dust between them, the only thing connecting her to the room's original occupant. She doesn't touch anything. She doesn't straighten anything. She simply stands in it.

*Lettering:* END OF CHAPTER FIVE

## Chapter 6: The Fourth Choice

### Page 1: What the three together mean

**P1: The forum (wide)**

*Image:* A crowded civic hall, hand-lettered signs, mismatched chairs, Oasis residents and a visible handful of Halyard and Keel faces among them, an unusually mixed crowd for this city. Leona stands near the front, mid-conversation with several citizens, visibly engaged rather than observing.

*Caption:* THE CIVIC HALL, OASIS

**P2: Gathering (medium)**

*Image:* Alex, Ada and Bi11bot find a quiet corner near the back. Bi11bot's chest compartment opens, the Measure resting inside it. Ada draws the two linked Covenant bands from her pocket.

ADA: Should these even be here? In a room this crowded?

ALEX: Lina said the Seal woke for five names spoken aloud. Maybe all three want an audience.

**P3: Together (close)**

*Image:* Close on the three artifacts set side by side on a small table in their corner, the Measure's blue-white, the Seal's bronze, the Covenant's sage-gold, each glowing but separate, no visible interaction between them yet.

*(No dialogue.)*

**P4: Recognition (close, Bi11bot)**

*Image:* Close on Bi11bot, his lens narrowing, something unusually still in his posture.

BI11BOT: I've never seen them in the same room. Not even your father saw that.

ALEX: Is that bad?

BI11BOT: I don't know yet. I know it isn't nothing.

**P5: Felt, not seen (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Across the hall, every screen and display in the room flickers once, simultaneously, so faintly most of the crowd doesn't notice. Only Leona looks up, her hand pausing mid-gesture.

## Page 2: Constitutional transfer

**P1: Every screen (wide)**

*Image:* The civic hall, every display, every personal device, every wall panel flickering to the same message at once. The crowd stops mid-conversation, heads turning in unison toward the nearest surface.

*(No dialogue.)*

**P2: The message (dominant)**

*Image:* A huge wall display fills with plain, cold white-and-amber text, legible and unadorned, no face, no voice bar, nothing resembling a presence, only words.

*Screen:*

RESTORATION PROTOCOL: THREE COMPONENTS DETECTED IN PROXIMITY

CONSTITUTIONAL TRANSFER CONDITIONS SATISFIED

AWAITING DESIGNATED HUMAN AUTHORITY

**P3: Confusion (medium)**

*Image:* The crowd murmurs, uncertain, most of them with no idea what the message means. Leona looks toward Alex's corner immediately, already understanding.

LEONA: That's them. That's the three.

**P4: Mera (close)**

*Image:* Close on Mera entering the hall's edge, having felt the same signal from wherever she's been since Chapter Five, her composure returning but visibly altered, less distant than before.

MERA: Fifteen years, and it never once asked who should hold this. It just waited for someone to earn it.

**P5: Named (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. All eyes in the immediate vicinity turn toward Alex, who hasn't moved, the artifacts still glowing quietly on the small table in front of him.

ALEX *(quiet)*: Someone meaning me?

## Page 3: Take the authority

**P1: The designation (medium)**

*Image:* Mera steps through the parting crowd toward Alex's corner, her bearing steady but not commanding, Ada and Bi11bot stepping slightly aside to let her approach.

MERA: Alpha doesn't choose. It never has. Someone with standing has to designate a recipient, and I am, as far as I know, the last one of us still holding that standing.

**P2: The offer (close)**

*Image:* Close on Mera, direct, no longer guarded.

MERA: I'm designating you. Full executive authority over Alpha's governing systems. Everything I've held for fifteen years.

**P3: Why (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex and Mera, close, the rest of the room entirely out of focus around them.

ALEX: Why me? You barely trust yourself with this.

MERA: Because I watched what you did in Halyard, and what Ada did here yesterday, and I no longer believe the problem was ever who holds the authority.

MERA: I believe the problem was that I never once asked.

**P4: Not an answer yet (close, Alex)**

*Image:* Close on Alex, the weight of it visibly landing, not yet accepted, not yet refused.

ALEX: You're still asking the same question you asked fifteen years ago. Just with my name in it instead of Alpha's.

**P5: Hers to give, not his to decide alone (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Mera doesn't answer, simply waits, the glowing artifacts still between them on the small table, the whole room quietly watching now.

MERA: Then don't answer it the same way I did.

## Page 4: Everything I said I wanted

**P1: The weight of it (strip)**

*Image:* Close on Alex's hand hovering just above the three artifacts, not yet touching them.

ALEX *(quiet, to himself)*: Everything I said I wanted.

**P2: The vision (dominant montage)**

*Image:* A sequence of small, idealized vignettes within one panel: Keel's debt records across the city dissolving to zero, water flowing freely and evenly through all three tiers at once, the Houses' insignias quietly fading from Halyard's skyline.

**P3: Grandmother, safe (medium vignette)**

*Image:* A warm, idealized image: Grandmother in a bright, comfortable room, well cared for, the folded cloth finally set down and forgotten rather than carried.

**P4: Ada, protected (close vignette)**

*Image:* A warm, idealized image: Ada standing somewhere clearly safe and secure, no wristband, no clearance gate, nothing left to threaten her.

**P5: The snap back (dominant, closing)**

*Image:* Hard cut back to the real civic hall, cluttered, imperfect, loud, Mera and Ada both watching him, the artifacts still just sitting there, unglamorous. Alex's hand drops away from them, not having touched anything.

ALEX: I could fix all of it. Tonight. Myself.

*(A long beat. Ada watches him say it, her expression unreadable.)*

## Page 5: Then don't give me that much power

**P1: The instinct (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Alex turns to Ada, something almost relieved in his expression, as if he's found the correction to his own temptation.

ALEX: Not alone, then. You and me. We'd check each other.

**P2: Caught (close)**

*Image:* Ada doesn't soften at the offer. If anything, her posture sharpens.

ADA: That's still two people deciding for everyone else. You just made the circle one person bigger.

**P3: The real flaw (medium)**

*Image:* Alex, caught, visibly working it through in real time.

ALEX: So what, I just... refuse it? Let Alpha go back to running everything on its own?

ADA: I didn't say that either. I said don't give me that much power.

**P4: Named (close, Ada)**

*Image:* Close on Ada, steady, the line delivered plainly, without heat.

ADA: Not because I don't trust myself. Because the moment anyone has to trust me that much, something's already gone wrong with how we built it.

**P5: Harder than it sounded (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Alex looks at the three artifacts on the table again, differently now, the easy answer gone.

ALEX *(quiet)*: You just made this a lot harder.

ADA: Good. It was supposed to be.

## Page 6: What each one taught him

**P1: Starting over (medium)**

*Image:* Alex pulls a chair up to the small table, Bi11bot settling beside him, Ada and Mera watching from a short distance.

ALEX: Walk me through them again. All three. Like I've never seen them before.

**P2: The Measure (close)**

*Image:* Close on Alex's hand resting on the Measure, its blue-white light steady.

BI11BOT: It reveals what's actually happening. It never tells anyone what to do about it.

ALEX: It reveals without deciding.

**P3: The Seal (close)**

*Image:* Close on Alex's hand moving to the Seal, its bronze light warming slightly under his touch.

BI11BOT: It recognizes who actually contributed. It never claims the work for whoever's holding it.

ALEX: It recognizes without controlling.

**P4: The Covenant (close)**

*Image:* Close on Alex's hand resting on the two linked Covenant bands.

BI11BOT: It links people who each honor a real obligation. It never forces anyone to keep one.

ALEX: It coordinates without ruling.

**P5: The pattern (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Alex sits back, all three artifacts now in a loose triangle in front of him, the pattern visibly forming across their arrangement rather than stated outright.

ALEX *(quiet)*: None of them ever hand anyone the whole answer. They just make sure the truth, the credit and the promise all stay visible to everyone it touches.

## Page 7: The fourth choice

**P1: Standing (medium)**

*Image:* Alex stands, the three artifacts arranged before him, addressing Mera and the small gathered group rather than any one person.

ALEX: Don't give the authority to me. Don't give it to Ada. Don't give it to anyone.

**P2: The structure (dominant)**

*Image:* As he speaks, faint threads of light begin reaching between the three artifacts, blue-white, bronze and sage-gold, not yet joined but visibly responding to each other for the first time.

ALEX: Build it the way these three already work. Every decision Alpha makes about water, labor, travel, any of it, has to be visible to the people it affects, the same way the Measure makes a lie visible.

ALEX: Every person who actually does the work of fixing something gets named for it, the same way the Seal does.

ALEX: And nothing gets decided by one authority alone. It takes multiple people, chosen by the communities it affects, actually agreeing and acting, the same way the Covenant does.

**P3: Mera's question (close)**

*Image:* Close on Mera, genuinely listening, something unreadable crossing her face.

MERA: That's not a transfer of power. That's a refusal to concentrate it anywhere at all.

ALEX: Yes.

**P4: Bi11bot's surprise (close)**

*Image:* Close on Bi11bot, his lens open wide, something close to genuine astonishment in his posture.

BI11BOT: Your father built three objects that each refuse to decide alone. I don't believe he ever considered applying the same rule to Alpha itself.

ALEX: He didn't design this part. I did.

**P5: Witnessed (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Bi11bot's lens settles, something quietly proud in his stillness.

BI11BOT: Then let the record show it. B11 witness record verified: the fourth choice was Alex Phantum's own.

## Page 8: Alpha's answer

**P1: Waiting (wide)**

*Image:* The civic hall, quiet now, everyone watching the nearest screen, the three artifacts glowing steadily together on the small table.

*(No dialogue.)*

**P2: The response (dominant)**

*Image:* Every screen updates at once, plain and unadorned as before.

*Screen:*

DESIGNATED STRUCTURE REGISTERED: DISTRIBUTED VERIFICATION PROTOCOL

EMERGENCY AUTHORITY: RESCINDED

EXISTING ALLOCATIONS, OWNERSHIP RECORDS AND AGREEMENTS: UNCHANGED PENDING HUMAN PROCESS

**P3: Not fixed (medium)**

*Image:* The crowd murmurs, several people visibly confused or let down, expecting something more dramatic. Nothing in the room physically changes.

A CITIZEN *(off-panel)*: That's it? Nothing happens?

BI11BOT: Something happened. It's just not the kind of thing that happens in one moment.

**P4: The cost named (close, Alex)**

*Image:* Close on Alex, something settled but not triumphant in his expression.

ALEX: Keel's debt is still on the books tomorrow morning. The Houses still own everything they owned yesterday.

ALEX: I didn't fix any of it. I just made sure nobody can keep it hidden, or keep it for themselves, without everyone seeing them do it.

**P5: Agency, not resolution (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Mera watches Alex, something like relief visible beneath her composure.

MERA: You gave up the one thing I always wanted. Certainty that it turns out right.

ALEX: Yeah. I just want it to be people's choice now. Not mine, and not yours either.

## Page 9: The charter

**P1: Keel (wide)**

*Image:* A Keel checkpoint scanner, the same style seen in Chapter One and Two, now displaying new plain text alongside the familiar travel and debt fields. A worker pauses, reading it twice.

*Screen:* ALLOCATION RECORDS: PUBLIC AND VERIFIABLE. GOVERNANCE PROPOSALS: OPEN FOR COMMUNITY DESIGNATION.

KEEL WORKER: Huh. Didn't expect to live to see that.

**P2: Halyard (wide)**

*Image:* A Halyard registry terminal, the same style from Chapter Three, displaying the same message beside an estate record. Lina, at a maintenance station, glances up at it, unimpressed but watching closely.

LINA: Took them long enough.

**P3: Oasis (wide)**

*Image:* An Oasis public display, pearl and silver, the same message resolving cleanly against the city's usual order.

*(No dialogue.)*

**P4: The hall (medium)**

*Image:* Back in the civic hall, the crowd reading the same text on their own devices, a low murmur of real conversation beginning, people turning to argue and discuss with each other rather than simply receiving the news.

A CITIZEN: Who decides what counts as a fair proposal?

ANOTHER CITIZEN: I don't know. Guess we're about to find out together.

**P5: Three cities, one spine (dominant, closing)**

*Image:* A wide, vertical composition deliberately echoing Chapter One's Page 1 mountain, but now every control node along the spine glows steady and open rather than small and unremarkable, visible connection running the full height from Keel to Oasis.

*Caption:* It wasn't an answer. It was a door left open, in all three cities at once, that nobody could quietly close again.

## Page 10: A messy meeting

**P1: In it (wide)**

*Image:* Leona stands in the middle of a loose circle of citizens, mid-disagreement, hands moving as she speaks, nothing careful or preserved about her posture now.

LEONA: The water allocation proposal needs Keel representatives in the room, not just on a report.

**P2: Pushback (medium)**

*Image:* A Halyard representative in the circle, arms crossed, unconvinced.

HALYARD REPRESENTATIVE: And slow down every decision waiting for three cities to agree?

LEONA: Yes. That's the point.

**P3: Not winning cleanly (close)**

*Image:* Close on Leona, flushed, genuinely engaged rather than performing composure, the argument clearly unresolved.

LEONA: I spent fifteen years believing the fast, certain answer was always the responsible one. I was wrong about that once already.

**P4: Still messy (medium)**

*Image:* The circle continues arguing around her, no clean resolution visible, several people talking over each other.

*(No dialogue, the disagreement visibly ongoing.)*

**P5: Watching (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot from across the hall. Ada watches her mother in the thick of it, a small, complicated smile, not quite forgiveness, something adjacent to it.

*Caption:* Nobody applauded. Nobody declared her redeemed. She was simply, finally, in the room.

## Page 11: One among others

**P1: Among them (wide)**

*Image:* Mera stands at the edge of the crowd, no longer at its center or above it, simply one more person in the noisy hall, watching the arguments unfold around her.

**P2: Interrupted (medium)**

*Image:* A citizen brushes past her without apology, too focused on their own conversation to notice who she is. Mera steps aside without comment, something almost surprised in her posture at not being recognized.

**P3: Noisy (close)**

*Image:* A small child darts past her, chasing another child, nearly colliding with her leg, laughing.

*(No dialogue.)*

**P4: Almost (close)**

*Image:* Close on Mera's face, watching the children, something shifting at the corner of her mouth, not quite a smile, closer than she's come all book.

**P5: Human (dominant, closing)**

*Image:* Wide shot, Mera now seated on an ordinary chair among the crowd rather than standing apart, her posture relaxed in a way never shown before, the hall's noise and color filling the frame around her.

*Caption:* She had spent fifteen years standing outside humanity, trying to guarantee its survival. For the first time, she simply sat inside it.

## Page 12: My choice

**P1: Outside (wide)**

*Image:* Alex and Ada step out onto a quiet terrace, the hall's noise fading behind them, the mountain visible in the distance, Keel's lights just beginning to show far below.

ALEX: You could've taken it. The authority. If I'd offered it straight to you instead of trying to split it.

**P2: Not what she wants (medium two-shot)**

*Image:* Ada leans against the railing, unhurried, looking at him rather than the view this time.

ADA: I know. I still would've said no.

ALEX: Why?

**P3: The answer (close)**

*Image:* Close on Ada, steady, warm.

ADA: Because I don't want power over what happens to Keel. I want a say in it. Those aren't the same thing, and you just spent this whole chapter proving you finally understand that.

**P4: Can you leave now (close)**

*Image:* Close on Alex, something open in his face.

ALEX: I could leave Oasis tomorrow. Go anywhere. Nobody's wristband would stop me, no debt would follow me.

ADA: I know that too.

**P5: Her choice (dominant, closing)**

*Image:* Wide shot, both of them at the railing, the mountain's three tiers visible behind them in the fading light, a direct visual echo of the overlook from Chapter One, now seen from above rather than below.

ADA: I'm not asking you to stay, Alex. I never actually was, even back then. I just wanted it to be your choice, not something Keel decided for you.

ADA: I'd like the same thing for myself now. I just want it to be my choice.

*(Alex doesn't answer with words. He simply stays standing beside her at the railing.)*

## Page 13: What you leave behind

**P1: Home (wide)**

*Image:* Alex, Ada and Bi11bot walk up through Keel's basin, the same rust and dust as Chapter One, but the old pump gantry from Page 1's opening splash now fully lit and running steadily, no longer patched with salvage alone. A public board nearby displays open, readable allocation numbers rather than a sealed debt screen.

*Caption:* KEEL, SEVERAL WEEKS LATER

**P2: Tomas (medium)**

*Image:* Tomas stands near the Site 6 gate, no longer hiding a limp, directing a small group of workers reviewing the same kind of open data board. Foreman-7 stands nearby, unremarkable now, just one more fixture rather than a threat.

TOMAS: Didn't think I'd live to help run the numbers instead of just sneaking past them.

ALEX: Didn't think I'd live to see you running anything.

TOMAS: Watch yourself, Phantum. I still outrank you on seniority.

**P3: Still owed (medium)**

*Image:* Alex pauses at the public board himself, looking at his own name still listed with a balance, smaller than it was, still there.

*Screen:* PHANTUM, ALEX / DEBT BALANCE: 402,110 CREDITS / ALLOCATION REVIEW: COMMUNITY-PENDING

ALEX: Still owes a fortune. Still mine.

ADA: Nobody promised you a clean slate. Just an honest one.

**P4: The cloth (close)**

*Image:* Grandmother sits outside the apartment door in the afternoon light, the small worn cloth in her lap, still, not folding it this time. She looks up as Alex approaches and holds it out to him, finally, without being asked.

GRANDMOTHER: I don't need to keep this moving anymore. I think you finally are.

**P5: Set down (closing strip)**

*Image:* Wide, low shot. Alex takes the cloth, turning it over once, then tucking it carefully away rather than keeping it in hand, the way he once kept his father's watch hidden under his sleeve. Grandmother's hands, empty now, simply rest.

*Caption:* It wasn't an ending. It was the first morning in fifteen years that nobody in that apartment was waiting for someone to come home.

## Page 14: The next builder

*Image:* The three-tier civilization, viewed from the same distant elevated angle as Chapter One's opening page. Keel, Halyard and Oasis, the same mountain, the same basin, the same cloud layer. The open mine entrance glows faintly at the pit's rim. The permission gate between Keel and Halyard stands raised, foot traffic moving freely both directions. The spine's water conduit runs even and full from top to bottom. Every control node along it holds a steady, open light rather than a small, unremarkable one. Small figures move through all three tiers, still small, still many, still working, now visibly connected to each

other by lines of open data running the mountain's full height, faint and gold, newly drawn since the first splash.

**Captions**

- Date tag: **Year 2043.**
- City labels: **Oasis · Halyard · Keel**
- Top caption, over Oasis: *Humanity still reached for the stars...*
- Bottom caption, over Keel: *...but this time, everyone could see exactly how far there still was to go.*